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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

ELECTION IS LIFE OF DEMOCRACY: PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The Election Commission (EC) on Friday submitted its annual report of the fiscal year 2022/23 to President Ramchandra Paudel.

Chief Election Commissioner Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya presented the 17th annual report to President Paudel in accordance with the Article 294 of the Constitution at a ceremony held at the Office of the President.

On the occasion, President Paudel thanked the EC for successfully concluding the elections of the House of Representatives (HoR) and Provincial Assemblies, of the President and Vice President and the by-elections of the HoR last year.

President Paudel expressed his confidence that the Nepal government would take action to address the concerns highlighted in the report.

Stating that the periodic election is the life of democracy, and the people practice democracy by participating in the electoral process, he appreciated the EC for timely concluding the elections. He expressed his hope that the EC would continue to effectively fulfill the duties and obligations laid out by the Constitution and election law of Nepal.

President Paudel also expressed his confidence that the Nepal government would take action to address the concerns highlighted in the report.

Chief Election Commissioner Thapaliya presented a summary of major events conducted by the EC in the last fiscal year.

He said that the EC was functioning abiding by the constitution and laws.

He mentioned that the draft of Integrated Election Law (Election Management Bill) formulated incorporating suggestions to enhance the election management and processes, was already approved by the EC and submitted to the government through the Ministry of Home Affairs.

According to the report, the EC has held a total of 190 meetings and made 637 decisions in the last fiscal year.

The EC said it has conducted election of HoR and Provincial Assemblies on November 20, 2022, by-election of National Assembly on February 8, 2023, presidential election on March 9, 2023, vice-presidential election on March 17, 2023 and by-election of HoR on April 23, 2023. The EC had established 10,892 polling station, 22,227 polling centres and 141 temporary polling stations thought out the country during the election of HoR and National Assembly held in 2022.

During the election, 61.5 per cent voters cast votes.

According to the report, EC had received a budget of Rs. 8.50 billion for the HoR and the Provincial Assembly elections. Of that, Rs. 6.55 was spent and remaining Rs. 1.94 billion was returned to the Finance Ministry.

Election Commissioners and Secretary of the EC were present on the occasion.

PM inaugurates nation's second largest power substation

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Inaruwa, Dec. 22

A 400 kV capacity Inaruwa substation constructed in Bhokraha Narsingh Rural Municipality-4 of Sunsari district has been inaugurated.

Built to strengthen the electricity transmission and distribution system, it is the second-largest substation in Nepal after the Dhalkebar substation.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' inaugurated the substation based on the gas insulated system (GIS) at Bhokraha in Sunsari on Friday.

Two substations of 400 and 220 kV have been constructed in Inaruwa.

The 400 kV substation has been constructed in Inaruwa under the National Electricity Development Decade Programme in the joint investment of the government and the Nepal Electricity Authority.

Three 400 kV substations were proposed under the programme, and the first was built in Dhalkebar, Dhanusha, while the one built in Inaruwa is the second. Construction of the third 400 kV has reached the final stage in Hetauda.

Likewise, the 220/132/33 kV substation was built under the Nepal-India Electricity Transmission and Trade Project with the investment of the government and the Authority and the World Bank's subsidised loan.

The construction cost of the 400 kV and 200 kV substations is about Rs. 3.83 billion.

After inaugurating the substation, Prime Minister Prachanda said that it was constructed and inaugurated to address the domestic electricity demand and export it to India and Bangladesh.

He said that the substation would help the electricity trade with India and Bangladesh and improve the economy of Nepal.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the completion of such large-scale infrastructures has sent a message of hope at a time when despair was being spread among people that nothing was done in the country.

He said that the substation has solved the problem of local power tripping.

"The Inaruwa substation has been established as a hub for east-west electricity supply and electricity trade with the neighbouring country India," he said. "It will light not only the houses and settlements but will also contribute to the country's prosperity and development."

Recalling that the government led by him in the past had freed the people from the terrible era of long-hour load-shedding and taken forward the journey of bright Nepal, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "At that time there was the problem of load-shedding in the urban areas and more than half of the country's villages were still in the dark, now about 98 per cent of the population has access to electricity. The golden day to announce complete electrification of the country within one to two years is coming soon."

He said that the government was making important decisions on the use of forest areas for the construction of transmission lines.

"Within a few days, we are making some historic and important decisions to distribute land to the landless squatters. My first year in office is going to be completed soon. Now onward, we will work to push development activities further forward and maintain good governance," he said.

"The initial agreement inked on long-term electricity trade with India during my visit to the southern neighbour has ensured the market to develop the immense potential of hydropower in Nepal. To implement the initial agreement, we are soon signing the final agreement in the presence of the high level Indian officials in Nepal, this will be another important and historic opening in Nepal's hydropower development," he said.

On the occasion, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet said that energy had contributed significantly to the development of the country.

He said that the substation proved to be an important milestone not only in the development of electricity but also in exploiting water resources.

He said that development has given hope rather than despair and that the current government has done many things that have not been done since 1968 B.S.

Minister Basnet said that 500 megawatts of electricity was produced within one year and another 500 megawatts of electricity would be added to the national grid in the next year.

Mentioning that there is a reliable base to produce about 30,000 megawatts of electricity within the next 10 years, Minister Basnet said that additional legal arrangements will be made to address the right-of-way problem and the demands of the locals for the construction of the transmission lines.

Managing director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the Inaruwa substation is the backbone for the transmission of electricity produced by hydropower projects in various districts of Koshi Province for local consumption and export to India.

This substation will help improve the local supply of power, he said. "This will improve the voltage in the area and the electricity supply will be reliable and qualitative."

"The Inaruwa-Purnia 400 kV international line for electricity trade with India and Inaruwa-Anarmani 400 kV transmission line for trade between Nepal, India and Bangladesh has been proposed from this substation," he said.

The 400/220 kV Inaruwa substation has three power transformers, each having a capacity 315 MVA.

Similarly, there are two power transformers of 220/132 kV 160 MVA capacity and 220/33 kV, 63 MVA capacity.

After the construction of the Inaruwa-Dhalkebar 400 kV transmission line, around 4,000 megawatts of electricity can be supplied from the Inaruwa substation. The wire pulling of the Inaruwa-Dhalkebar transmission line is now underway.



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' observing Inaruwa sub-station after its inauguration in Jhokraha of Sunsari on Friday.

Road to Prosperity

- Two substations of 400 and 220 kV have been constructed in Inaruwa.
- The construction cost of the 400 kV and 200 kV substations is about Rs. 3.83 billion.
- The substation will help the electricity trade with India and Bangladesh.

'ECONOMY IS NOT IN DIRE SITUATION'

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 22

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the country's economy is not in a dire situation like it was a year ago. While speaking at the inaugural programme of a trade expo organised by the Chamber of Industries Morang (CIM) on Friday in Biratnagar, the Prime Minister said that the indicators of the economy were positive.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that with the help of the private sector, the inflation which was at 7.11 per cent has come down to 5.38 per cent now. Stating that a comfortable situation has been created in terms of balance of payments, he clarified that there were signs of improvement in bank interest rates while the situation is being improved in micro-finance and cooperatives sectors as well. Stating that in the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 Nepal is witnessing Rs. 120 billion remittance inflow every month, PM Prachanda said that the reserve of the current FY is at Rs. 16.96 billion. "Some14 months ago, the loan interest rate had reached above 18 per cent, now it is below 12 per cent," he said.

Stating that good governance and social justice had been established one year after he took the reign of the government, he asked to turn the criticism into a positive one. PM Prachanda expressed concerns over the negative nature of civil and business activities and comments even though the economy is getting back on track, and emphasised that intellectuals and industrialists should come forward to change this into a positive one.

Stating that Biratnagar has political significance, PM Prachanda maintained that any argument of non-cooperation in the development of this city cannot be accepted. He said that the policy problems in the operation of the inaugurated cargo rail will be resolved immediately, Girija Prasad Koirala Cricket Stadium will be promoted as a project of national pride and the government will be positive in ensuring the budget for the ring road in the coming Fiscal Year 2024/25.

Similarly, PM Prachanda assured that a decision will be taken soon on the matter of maintaining the entry permit through the checkpoint and maintaining the affiliation of Koshi to Mount Everest to facilitate the arrival of tourists in the provincial capital of Koshi.

Speaking on the occasion, Nepali Congress leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala, complained that although Biratnagar is standing on its own feet, the government was not paying attention to development. He demanded that the federal government address the issues at Biratnagar Ring road, Bathanaha-Viratnagar cargo rail, Biratnagar airport upgradation and industrial exhibition.

Meanwhile, industrialists and businesspersons of Biratnagar facilitated Prime Minister Prachanda.

'Digital technology must for economic transformation'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that digital transformation and building a digital ecosystem are necessary for the economic transformation of the country.

Addressing the eighth edition of the ICT Awards organised by Living with ICT on Friday, Minister Sharma said that the government was formulating necessary policy, legal and structural arrangements for this transformation.

She said, "The government considers information and communication technology (ICT) as a basic need and a national priority."

Minister Sharma said that information technology was an important basis for the development of the digital economy, and to compete with the world.

Minister Sharma further stressed that the government has passed the National Cyber Security Policy-2080 B.S (2023), to create cyber laws and establish a National Cyber Security Centre.

Minister Sharma also informed that the government was organising new programmes like ICT Exhibition and Digital Champion to encourage start-ups in the information technology sector this year.

Minister Sharma stressed that digital skill programmes would be implemented in all seven provinces to retain youths in the country by creating job opportunities.

Bardiya boy's app sold at Rs. 7 million

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Dec. 22

A mobile application developed by 22-year-old Karna Bahadur Budha Chhetri has sold for over Rs. 7 million.

Chhetri, who lives in Bansgadhi Municipality-5, Bardiya, and has a diploma in computer engineering from the Nepalgunj Technical College, made an app called 'Pickup Lines.' And, according to his college, the Israeli company Rounds AI Ltd. purchased it for US$ 53,000.

Talking to The Rising Nepal, Chhetri said that his app contained a collection of pickup lines that would help people have sweet, fun and memorable conversations with their friends and family members.

He said that the app would run on all versions of Android above Android 5.1 and informed that he had uploaded the app to the Google Play Store in November of last year. Since



then, it has been downloaded over 500,000 times, he said.

"The pickup lines in the app have been divided into cheesy, romantic, cute, funny and other categories. The users can easily copy the lines and paste them on social media chats, emails or text messages," Chhetri said. "The app was attracting a lot of users from Africa and Europe and had started to make good money."

Chhetri also informed that Rounds AI had made a previous offer to buy his app. But the money was too low. They later upped their offer and convinced him to sell.

Kishor Kumar Pandey, managing director of Nepalgunj Technical College, said that the entire college was extremely proud of Chhetri's achievement and wished him further success in the future.

Meanwhile, the college's Principal Chhining Lal Thapa Magar hoped that Chhetri would inspire other students as well.

To date, Chhetri has developed over a dozen apps and has uploaded them to Play Store under the name 'Kaki Developers.' Some of those apps have over 100,000 downloads.

Some of Chhetri's most popular apps include 'Class 9 Nepali Guide Book,' 'Class 8 Nepali Guide Book,' 'Nepali Byakaran' and 'Nepali Samaya Gyan Offline.'

NC'S BAGMATI PROVINCE CONFERENCE TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

Nepali Congress Bagmati Province Committee decided to hold the party's first Bagmati conference on Saturday.

Committee chair Indra Bahadur Baniya organising a press meet in the Capital on Friday informed that preparations for the conference were completed.

NC president Sher Bahadur Deuba will inaugurate the conference which will be attended by the province representatives of 13 districts.

Baniya said that the agenda of the conference were federalism, secularism and a proportional electoral system.

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NRB to issue treasury bills of Rs. 17.11 billion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22



The Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) is issuing treasury bills worth Rs. 17.11 billion. The Monetary Management Department under the central bank has issued an auction for the 28-day, 91-day and 364-day treasury bills to obtain internal debt on behalf of the government.

The NRB is going to sell 28-day treasury bills worth Rs. 5 billion, 91-day bills worth Rs. 10.112 billion and 363-day treasury bills worth Rs. 2 billion through auction, according to the Treasury Bill Auction notice of the bank made public on Friday.

The bank called interested parties to submit their sealed auction trading application by 3 pm Sunday (December 24, 2023). The bidders should bid through the Online Bidding System (OBS) only. The allocated amount will be settled through NRB Bank Account, it said.

The bank said that the treasury bills will be allocated on December 27, 2023 (Wednesday). "Discount earning is taxable. Out of the total offered amount, 15 per cent was reserved for non-competitive bidders," the notice read.

The 28-day treasury bill will mature on January 23, 2024, and the 91-day bill will mature on March 26, 2024. Similarly, the 365-day Treasury bill will mature on December 24, 2024. Earlier last week, the NRB sold treasury bills worth Rs. 11.33 billion.

Treasury bills are issued when the government needs money for a short period. It is a major instrument of the money market used by the central bank to raise internal debt for one year or less.

Sufficient chemical fertilizers to the farmers in Madhesh

RSS
Birgunj, (Parsa), Dec. 22

The farmers in the districts of Madhes Province won't have to face the short supply of chemical fertilizer this year for the winter crops including the wheat farming.

The Agricultural Inputs Company Limited, Madhes Province Regional Office, Birgunj, Parsa has said that needed quantity of DAP chemical fertilizer has been sent to the districts for wheat farming and the urea fertilizer is coming soon.

Head of the Provincial Office, Durga Prasad Pandey said that a total of 16,023 metric tons of DAP and 19,299 metric tons of urea have been sent to the districts till December 13. "Farmers need DAP in the time of sowing wheat seeds.

We have already supplied the received quantity of DAP fertilizers in the districts as per the quota," he said.

"The farmers need urea after three weeks of sowing the seeds during the time of irrigation. That too will arrive within some days.

Around 36,000 metric tons of urea is in the process of arriving," Pandey added.

With the availability of this volume, there will be no crisis of fertilizer for wheat farming, according to Pandey.

The Agricultural Inputs Company Limited, Madhes Province Regional Office, Birgunj, Parsa is responsible to supply chemical fertilizers in all eight districts of Madhes Province, 10 districts of Bagmati Province and Tanahun, Lamjung, Gorkha, Kaski, Parbat and other districts of Gandaki Province.

ILO launches Decent Work Country Programme

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The International Labour Organisation (ILO), the Government of Nepal, the employers' and the workers' organisations in Nepal jointly launched the Decent Work Country Programme (DWCP) for Nepal, 2023-2027 recently.

The DWCP for Nepal is built on the pillars of Jobs, Rights, and Partners, outlines a comprehensive plan for the next five years, the ILO informed.

The programme aims to create employment opportunities, foster sustainable enterprises and enhance social security.

According to the ILO, it places a strong emphasis on International Labour Standards, focusing on fundamental principles and rights at work, and commits to strengthening government, employers', and workers' organisations to facilitate effective social dialogue.

Speaking at a programme organised in the capital to launch the programme on Wednesday, ILO's Country Director, Numan Özcan, said that the DWCP was a reflection of the shared ambition of ILO, government, workers, and employers.

"It is a compass guiding us to create opportunities for productive work, ensuring fair income, workplace security and social protection," he said.

Speaking on the occasion, UN Resident Coordinator, Hanaa Singer-Hamdy said that if Nepal is to achieve the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) targets and have a smooth and sustainable graduation from the Least Developed Country (LDC), all need to work together to effectively create more and better jobs in Nepal. She stressed the need to devise a resilient policy to benefit from the imminent graduation of Nepal from the least developed countries.

Kewal Prasad Bhandari, Secretary at the Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security, called for a strong commitment from all the partners and stakeholders for the effective and successful implementation of the DWCP as it would help in achieving the 2030 agenda.

Likewise, Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI), said that Nepal was currently facing economic turbulence and that graduation from LDC also comes with potential challenges.

"The DWCP at this critical point represents both our vision for overcoming existing challenges, and our hope for a better future. The DWCP is a document created through tripartite collaboration and is perhaps unique among country programmes across development agencies," he said.

Binod Shrestha, President of the Joint Trade Union Coordination Centre (JTUCC), stated that the implementation of labour-related laws, regulations, and international labour standards proved to be inadequate, resulting in workers being deprived of their fundamental labour rights.

Despite the establishment of a contribution-based social security system, a significant number of employers, including contractual employees within government institutions, have yet to implement it. We must take on the responsibility of bringing all workers into the social security system during the upcoming DWCP period, said Shrestha.

Minister Sharma stresses business promotion thru transparent advertising market



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Communications Minister Rekha Sharma addressing 24th Annual General Meeting of Nepal Advertising Board on Friday.

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec 22:

Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, has said only transparent advertising market based on healthy competition could promote the advertisement business.

Inaugurating the 24th annual general meeting of Advertising Association of Nepal (AAN) today, Minister Sharma underscored that a transparent advertising market would benefit advertisers, media and entrepreneurs.

She mentioned that overall economic sector of the country has been affected due to economic recession and the advertising market also hit hard due to this, adding human resources working in advertising market and media faced the problems due to economic recession.

"Advertising cycle has been affected due to the shrinkage of advertisement market. It can be believed that advertising market will grow with the increasing economic activities. It is necessary to pay attention to make advertising market more transparent and competitive," stressed the Communications Minister.

Minister Sharma shared that she started a process to make the advertising market transparent and competitive through amendment to advertising regulation. As she said, the information about extreme anomalies and commission in the advertisement distributed from government offices has made her serious.

Sugarcane farmers of Sarlahi call off protest



FILE PHOTO: TRN

Stored sugarcane in a cart.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Dec. 22

Agitating sugarcane farmers of Sarlahi district suspended their protest on Thursday. A meeting of the Sugarcane Farmers' Joint Struggle Committee on Thursday decided to suspend their district-centered protest and move to Kathmandu to exert pressure on the government.

The sugarcane farmers were staging the protest demanding the price of sugarcane be fixed at Rs. 750 per quintal this year. The farmers demanded that the subsidy amount of Rs.70 given by the government for the sugarcane sold a year ago should be paid as soon as possible.

Raj Kumar Upreti, president of Millgate Sugarcane Producers Committee, Sarlahi, said that they would stage a protest in Kathmandu after coordinating with representatives of sugarcane farmers from other districts.

He said that they decided to visit the concerned ministries and meet the parliamentarians so that their demands would be addressed. The government fixed the price of sugarcane at Rs. 635 per quintal with a government subsidy of Rs. 70 on Wednesday.

The sugarcane farmers of Sarlahi have not accepted the minimum price fixed by the government. The sugarcane farmers have demanded that the price of sugarcane should be fixed at Rs. 750 per quintal based on the increased price of sugar.

The Sugarcane Farmers Joint Struggle Committee issued a press statement on Thursday evening and demanded the assurance that the sugarcane farmers would get the declared subsidy amount after selling the sugarcane.

The government fixed the price of sugarcane but the farmers did not get the subsidy for the sugarcane they sold a year ago, prompting them to stage the protest.

With sugarcane farmers suspending their agitation, the country's largest sugar mill, Indushankar Sugar Mills, Harion, will start to crush the sugarcane within a few days.

The Indushankar has already issued letters to the farmers urging them to sell sugarcane. Sugarcane plants started drying in the field because of the delay in the operation of the sugar mill.

MINISTER GURUNG LAYS FOUNDATION STONE FOR BRIDGE

RSS
Dhulikhel, Dec. 22

Minister for Urban Development Sita Gurung laid the foundation stone for Patne Khola bridge and Patne Khola-Naya Basti-Durlung Khola road here today.The road will connect Bethanchok rural municipality in the district via Khopasi-Dhungakharka-Chamrangbesi-Phaparbari.

Minister Gurung said that the road would be developed as an alternative auxiliary road. "People would feel comfortable when plans at local level are completed on time. It is necessary to extend cooperation at time to play a role of watchdog for the timely completion of the projects as such."

The Urban Ministry has allocated Rs 20 million while Rs 4 million has been arranged by the Bethanchok, ward no 2 and 3, the Minister said.On a different note, she said that the federal government was ready to extend support for tourism development in Bethanchok rural municipality.Also speaking in the foundation stone laying ceremony, Bagmati Province Assembly member Kanchanchandra Bade Shrestha said that the road would be an access road for all the residents in Kavrepalanchowk and Makawanpur district.

Bethanchwk rural municipality Chairperson, Bhagawan Adhikari, shared that road connecting Khopasi to Bethanchok rural municipality was carried out and the upgrading of the same road was under way. Adhikari said that they were preparing to develop Shiva Parbati Gufa (cave), Bethanchok Narayanisthan and Tintale Jharana (three-storey waterfall) in the Bethanchok rural municipality as a tourism spot.

The estimated cost of Patnekhola bridge is over Rs 46 million. It is expected to be completed by mid-November, 2024.

'Pathao Super Fest-2023' launched

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

Pathao Nepal has announced the launch of 'Pathao Super Fest-2023' on the occasion of the New Year 2024 and Christmas. The scheme started from Thursday, December 21.

Aligned with the Super Fest theme, individuals in alien disguises, adorned with Pathao logo-printed clothes and bags, have been spotted across various locations in the Kathmandu Valley.

Pathao's Marketing Head, Surakshya Hamal revealed that the Super Fest encompasses not only enticing offers on Pathao Food but also includes various enjoyable offers on rides.

The company promises up to an 80 per cent discount on bike and car rides, as well as Pathao food.

Surprises including 20 pieces of Momos in one plate, a free burger with the purchase of fries, complimentary Momos with 'jhol' (soup) purchases, and free pizza, burger, omos, biryani, and aloo Dum are offered in the fest.

Hamal also said that the fest features daily flash sales from 9am to 9pm, along with enticing offers such as an 80 per cent discount on restaurant orders and free delivery services for Pathao Food.

Additionally, Pathao has arranged prizes for consumers during the Super Fest. With every order, customers will receive a Sureshot prize scratch card, ensuring that everyone is a winner of some prize.

Cardamom production increases in Ilam

RSS
Phikkal (Ilam), Dec. 22

Production of 11cardamom has increased in Ilam district. According to Agriculture Knowledge Centre Ilam, cardamom production has increased despite decrease in cardamom cultivated land.

Centre Chief Tony Bardewa shared that production of cardamom has increased by 7.96 per cent in current fiscal year as compared to previous fiscal year. Cardamom was planted on 1,753 hectares of land in the current fiscal year where 1320 metric tonnes of cardamom was produced. It was cultivated on 1,755 hectares of land in previous fiscal year where 1,215.26 metric tonnes was produced.

The productivity was 0.69 per cent per hectare in the previous fiscal year and it increased in the current fiscal year reached 0.75 per cent, he added.

Similarly, dragon fruit farming has been expanded in Ilam from this year.

It has been cultivated on 10 hectares of land in the current fiscal year against 0.5 hectares of land in the previous year, according to the Centre.



PHOTO: TRN

Chief Election Commissioner of Nepal Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya presenting the economic report of the Election Commission of Nepal 2079/80 BS to President Ramchandra Paudel in Kathmandu, Friday.

Warrant against Biplav 'wrong', says Madhav Nepal

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Narayangadh, Dec. 22

Chairman of CPN (Unified Socialist) and Coordinator of the Socialist Front Madhav Kumar Nepal has called the arrest warrant issued against leaders of the Nepal Communist Party (NCP), including General Secretary Netra Bikram Chand 'Biplav', wrong.

Talking to journalists at the Bharatpur Airport on Wednesday, Nepal asked the government not to arrest Biplav and other members of his party.

"We are together in the Socialist Front. We do have to look at legal arrangements but the way warrants have been issued against NCP members right now is not right," he said.

> The present partnership will continue. There is no possibility of any of our partners forming another alliance.

Earlier this month, the Kathmandu District Court issued arrest warrants against the NCP senior leaders.

Meanwhile, Nepal, who is also a former Prime Minister, said that the ruling coalition would remain intact for the upcoming National Assembly elections as well. He further said that the government would topple if the coalition broke.

"The present partnership will continue. There is no possibility of any of our partners forming another alliance," he added. "Forming a new coalition would mean forming a new government."

Admiring the government's actions against corruption, Nepal urged the authorities to take more stringent measures. "The government has started punishing those involved in corruption and has earned public praise for it," he said. "It needs to keep moving forward on this path with courage."

Two sustain bullet wounds in clash with police

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhalkebar, Dec. 22

Two were injured when police opened fire in a clash with locals at Suganikas of Hamsahpur Municipality-5, Dhanusha, on Friday.

Shankar Mandal, 36; and Matlab Ansari, 18, were injured in the police firing. Ansari is receiving treatment at the Provincial Hospital, Janakpur, while Madal was referred to Kathmandu for further treatment. The clash ensued after 60-year-old Deepa Mandal, who was in police detention, died.

When the angry locals picketed the Suganikas-based police office and began vandalising it, the police opened fire to disperse the demonstrators, said Dhanusha Police spokesperson Ranjan Awale.

"Accusing the police of beating Deepa to death, the angry locals attacked the police and set two motorcycles on fire, compelling the police to open the fire," he said. One local, Shankar Thakur, had beaten up and handed over Deepa to police, accusing him of stealing goods when the latter was trying to settle a dispute in his neighbourhood on Thursday night.

Locals claimed that Deepa died when police thrashed him.

Mayor of Hanshapur Municipality Pradeep Yadav said that Deepa received an injury in the head when the latter was trying to foil the dispute. "I do not know who hit him and with what, but he died while undergoing treatment," said Mayor Yadav.

Member of the House of Representatives Deepak Karki said that the incident was condemnable and demanded an independent investigation into the incident and legal actions against the culprit.

KMC gives Rs. 3 million to NCO

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The Kathmandu Metropolitan City has provided Rs. 3 million in assistance to the Nepal Children's Organisation.

The amount would be used for different purposes including managing housing, food and health care to the children living in the Organisation.

Deputy Mayor of KMC Sunita Dangol handed over the amount to Chairperson of Organisation Bidya Neupane.

On the occasion, Deputy Mayor Dangol said that the KMC doled out the assistance amount after receiving complaints about the challenges the Organisation was facing in the management of food and health care. In the current fiscal year, the KMC is to provide Rs. 5 million to the Organisation.

People urged to take precautions against cold

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, Meteorological Forecasting Division has urged people to take necessary precautions against cold as the temperature is on a decreasing trend across the country.

Cold has increased with the drop in mercury throughout the country, including in the Kathmandu Valley. The minimum temperature in Kathmandu on Friday dropped to 4.5 degrees Celsius and the maximum 19 degrees Celsius.

The minimum temperature in Kathmandu has been between 4 to 5 degrees Celsius and the maximum in the range of around 17 to 19 degrees Celsius since the last three to four days. Extreme cold has intensified in Kathmandu due to the fall in temperature. Although the days are sunny, much cold is experienced in the morning and evening.

The lowest temperature of minus 2.8 degrees Celsius is recorded in Jumla and minus 3.5 degrees Celsius in Jomsom, the Division said.

The Westerly wind has a partial impact in Nepal at present and the weather is partly cloudy to generally fair due to this weather system. It will be partly to generally cloudy in the hilly region of Koshi, Bagmati and Gandaki provinces and partly cloudy to generally fair in the rest of the provinces tonight.

The weather will be partly to generally cloudy in the hilly region of the above provinces and partly cloudy to mostly fair in the rest of the provinces on Saturday (December 23). There are chances of light rain in one or two places in the hilly regions of Sudurpaschim and Karnali provinces.

The Division stated that there is the possibility of light snowfall in one or two places of the high-hilly and mountainous region of Koshi, Gandaki, Karnali and Sudurpaschim provinces.

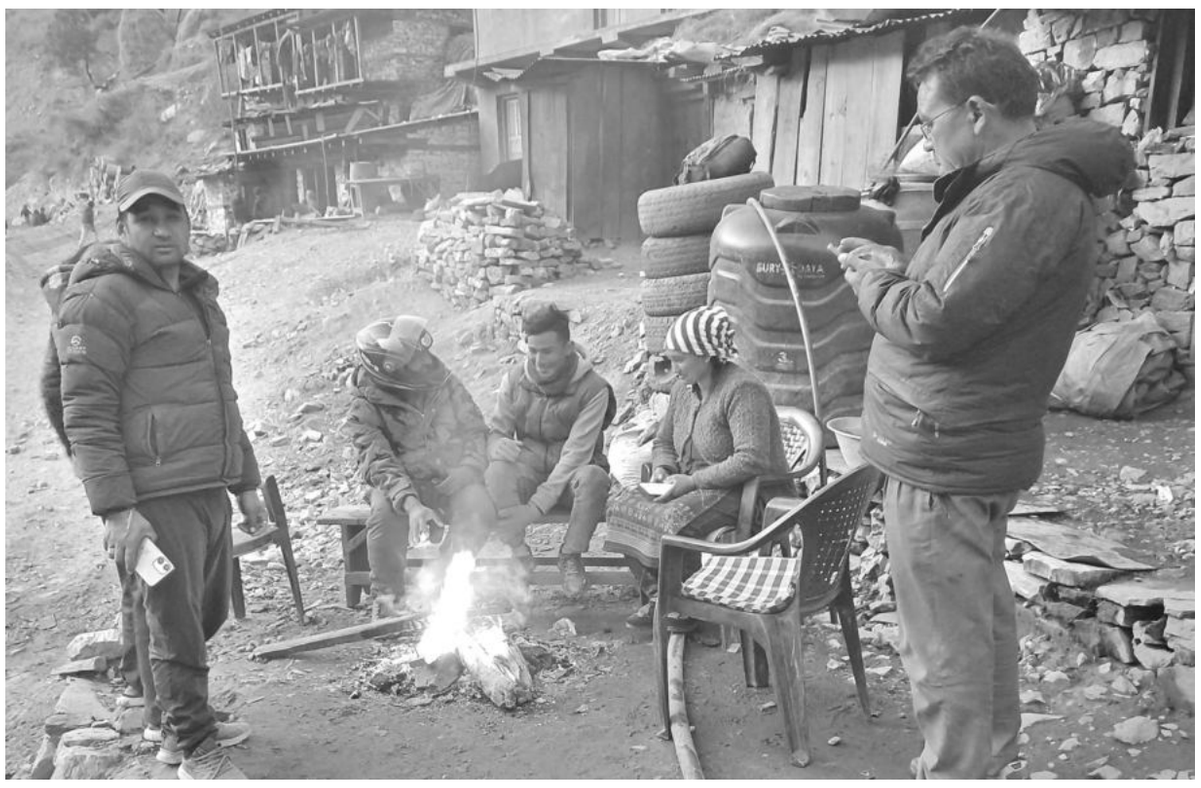


PHOTO: RSS

As the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, Meteorological Forecasting Division has urged people to take necessary precautions against cold as the temperature is on a decreasing trend across the country, the people are taking precaution from it.

Monkeys raiding Gulmi villages; Mayor Panthi seeks solution



PHOTO: TILACHAN PANDEY/TRN

Monkeys emptying Dubichaur village in Resunga Municipality-13, Gulmi.

BY TILACHAN PANDEY
Tamghas, Dec. 22

With rocks in both her hands, 52-year-old Rumkala Khatri is sitting in the yard of her home in Dubichaur village, Resunga Municipality-13, Gulmi. She sits out like this, all day, every day, to look out for intruders who come to her house without fear and eat all the food grains.

"They have no fear, I tell you," she yelled. "That is why I have these rocks. I have to hit them with it to make them go away." The monkeys have been troubling Khatri and her neighbours for years.

Previously, the simians only used to come in the fields. But now, they raid people's homes. "The pesky primates us to abandon farming. Now, they are forcing us out of our homes," Khatri complained.

Unable to defeat the monkeys, many kept their land fallow, Khatri shared with The Rising Nepal. The uncultivated land gradually turned to forest. This led to an increase in the number of monkeys and a rise in monkey menace.

Bel Bahadur Basnet, a businessman in the same village, also keeps stones like Khatri. He has tried to plant potatoes in the land near his shop but monkeys have not let him. "Monkeys have become our biggest enemies. They seem determined to push us out," he expressed his sadness.

This "monkey harassment" is providing an additional reason for people to leave villages, he said.

Lumkala Thapa, 74, said that the monkeys had become especially aggressive in the past six years and they created a vicious cycle. "Monkeys made people leave. This left land and houses empty. The empty land and houses were claimed by trees and bushes. This attracted more monkeys which, in turn, pushed more people out."

Last year, seventh grader Samjhana Thapa was viciously attacked by monkeys when she was returning home from school. The incident scared many parents and prompted them to leave with their children.

Absence of youths exacerbates problem

Local Min Bahadur Khatri said that the monkey problem was exacerbated by a lack of youths in the village. "Sons work abroad, daughters-in-law live in the cities with the kids, only old people are left in the area," he said. "Old people cannot chase away monkeys."

Half of all houses empty

Nearly 50 per cent of the houses in Siran, Harrarukh, Sallarukh, Dandabari and Kalleri areas in Dubichaur are now empty because their owners have migrated elsewhere. Villager Lokendra Khatri said that the emigration rates had skyrocketed in the past six years due to the monkeys.

Urmila Khatri said that people left because they could not bear the pain the monkeys were causing. "We plant crops, care for them and work hard in our fields throughout the year. But when it is time to reap the rewards, the monkeys destroy everything. It is heartbreaking."

Sudip Khatri, secretary of the Free Students Union of the Resunga Multiple Campus, worried that if the monkeys were not brought under control, Dubichaur would lose all its residents in the next five years. "If the federal government does not do anything, our hills will be filled with monkeys, not people."

Resunga's Mayor Khildhwoj Panthi also stressed that the federal government needed to provide a solution. He said that the local level had asked the centre to allow people to kill monkeys if they intruded on private land, just like it has for boars. If that is not possible, he asked the federal authorities to look into relocating the simians.

Statue of social worker Begha unveiled



PHOTO: TRN

A life-size statue of late Kumar Hang Begha, an education campaigner and a social reformer has been unveiled on the premises of Bishnu Secondary School of Chyangthapuka in Yangwarak Rural Municipality, Panchthar.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Phidim, Dec. 22

A life-size statue of the late Kumar Hang Begha, an education campaigner and a social reformer has been unveiled.

The statue of Begha was unveiled on the premises of Bishnu Secondary School of Chyangthapuka in Yangwarak Rural Municipality, Panchthar, on Thursday on the occasion of the 10th memorial day of late Bega.

Professor Dr. Govinda Raj Bhattarai unveiled the statue at a programme organised by Kumar Hang Begha Memorial Foundation. While unveiling the statue, Dr. Bhattarai said the contribution of late Begha to the field of education was notable, and the new generation has been following the path shown by the late Begha.

Sarad Adhikari, General Secretary of the Foundation, said that Begha contributed to the development of education by opening schools in different places of Panchthar and Taplejung districts from 1951 to 1968.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

All you need is the plan, the road map, and the courage to press on to your destination.
- Earl Nightingale

Quality Education As Incubator Of Progress

Dev Raj Dahal



Life itself is a learning process about the world-changing advance in science and technology, developing understanding by widening perspective and acquiring necessary skills to overcome the course of natural selection.

The optimal use of educational insight can help to improve conditions of living and gain practical experience to boost overall progress.

In a knowledge-driven society, economy and politics, liberal education releases a spark of self-perfection and improves other's lives even of those persons who are caught at the bottom of the social and economic pyramid. Nepal's adoption of a welfare state with right to education is expected to nurture the social mobility of the underclass. Its classical treatises have emancipatory impulse and vocational needs of social and economic systems.

The Upanishads sought to delink knowledge from rituals. Rational knowledge linked with the basic human values beyond self-interest, enables one to exercise a life of liberty, choice and innovation while spiritual knowledge helps to know self, others and oneness of all living species on whom human survival and progress rest.

Education is power and its effective use can enable one to cope with human nature by disciplining self, without colonising, dominating and crippling this oneness.

The fragmentary nature of sciences and social sciences into several branches has yet to awaken students to this oneness and find sensible choice. Education is a mark of civility. Its diffusion reduces the scale of violence, vices and prejudice.

Donation for lofty cause

Resonating the connectivity between conscience and sensitivity, many Nepalis have donated a large chunk of their wealth for the lofty cause of education and sought to enhance the sensibility, mobility, civility and leveling up of ordinary people. The synergy of knowledge and experience generates practical wisdom filled with blessing that makes personal and professional life mature, able to judge what is right and what is wrong. It has also made life entrepreneurial, satisfying and enjoyable. The social spirit of the educated Nepalis is important to attach them with each other and yearn for their love to the society of origin and the nation.

For acquiring knowledge Gautam Buddha focused on self-illumination, not authoritarian teaching of passive learners or a gift received from teachers only conforming fixed curriculum. Educational innovation is important for them to escape from self-alienation and perpetual trust in the advice and judgment of others regardless of its prudence. Active reflection is the basis of inquiry, curiosity and wonder. It establishes the utility of education for truth seeking, critical reasoning and subduing primordial passion so that education does not become a commodity to be sold and bought.

The unity of Nepalis sought within its culture and constitution can build robust citizenship while loitering outside can turn them either parochial or rootless clientalised to an unjust market. It perpetuates the harsh inequality of power which true education naturally despises. At a time where cross-fertilisation of knowledge has become a rule, cultural talent can build national confidence.

The bubble of entrepreneurship springing from the grassroots Nepali society can empower the belief of the educated to take effective leadership in replicating successes, build bridges across the nation's diversity through the exchange of ideas, goods and services and bring fresh impetus to the productive sectors. Rig Veda says, "If you don't implement your knowledge it becomes a burden." But if its seeds are infused with the stuff of abidya (false consciousness) rooted in earning money and political distinction, production and diffusion of praqgyan (flashing beams of intellectual light) turns thorny. It breeds dependency and defeats the very purpose of education to cultivate the autonomy of a person freed from self-subordination to political fracas unable to adapt to social aspirations.

Each year thousands of new generations of Nepali students are reared in scientific-technical, vocational, humanity and social sciences. Yet, after their journey to graduation, the ideas and ideals they had acquired from good teachers and the experience of discipline do not seem exhilarating because many of them find a divorce in their passion and profession in the process of flaring up their potential.

They face an uncertain future because education in Nepal is not attuned to a call to national service, get engaged in creative social life with full of supercilious purpose and freed self from the ordeal of national life. The splendid transformative power of education thus lost its grit and drive. The magnificent support students get from their families during the entire education-cycle though not reflected in the certificates is valuable and matchless without comparison.

The plot of their new pathways defined by the pull of the job market may offer new choices but family support is burden free which they do not have to pay back except affection to parents and grandparents. Rousseau says, "It is education that must give souls the national form, and so direct their tastes and opinions, that they will be patriotic by inclination, passion and necessity." In Nepal, convocation events mark an academic ritual.

It furnishes an elemental proof that students have fruitfully completed a course of study for which they are conferred with the university certificate with different scores. It assumes that they have acquired certain level of specialised knowledge and skills enabling them to know how the world of real life works. It can add a new feature in their personal bio-data.

> Prospects of egalitarian society underlined in the constitution are achievable with a massive dose of investment in the nation's public and community education system where private education can complement.

But the question is: have educational standards of Nepal made students functional to keep the nation's march to progress, or only opened personal career opportunity in various jobs, honed market-compatible minds hankering only after competitive salary, made them entrepreneurial or a lack of choice forced them to join global job market to breath an expression of secured life. Once they leave the college their successful leadership in various walks of life meets the vision of Nepali constitution.

Wherever they are, their emotional bond stays with their families, colleges, universities and the motherland as a sweet memory. In a highly competitive nature of the market, it is vital to make education efficient to catch up, compete and even excel in certain areas of its competitive advantage. Nepal is rich in natural resources, cultural capital, youth bulge and geostrategic site between two huge landmasses of Asia - India and China.

What is deeply amiss is the management ability of national leaders to utilise them for nation building despite their promises to modernise Nepal. The lack of political will and endless haggling for power and patronage consumed their vision and enfeebled their ability to change the educational face of the nation. Quality education can open the students to a new phase of life with prodigious intellectual gift, great passion and zeal. Students' future career depends on how they demonstrate the feat of artistic genius and technical capabilities and take responsibility as family members, educated persons, as citizens of Nepal and as universal human beings entitled with human rights. Deployment of knowledge to personal and social upliftment is elevating.

At a time of turbulent scientific and technological change and evolving management and behavioural practices the frontiers of knowledge and organisational boundaries are changing fast.

Nepali educational policy wonks must have to keep abreast with the innovative and complex changes thus anticipating the future of evolving educational management practices, update the curriculum and blend teachers' training and research. It enables the nation's competitive spirit in the world of education. Educated Nepalis are able to change their archaic belief system, outdated structures and practices attuning to new reality and consorting integrity, moral strength and the very purpose of education to connect with a cause which is larger than absolute self-interest and self-aggrandisement and enhance human ability and public good.

The business model of education tailors only the narrow motive of achievements in profit maximisation and discourages the cultivation of social virtue, civility and justice which are important to build character and disposition affirming democratic society. The prevailing crisis of value in Nepal's educational system can be ameliorated if educational institutions are free from unjust partisan politics.

Critical challenges

The ability to rise up to a series of critical challenges Nepal is facing depends on the quality of education and its practical utility. Constellation of diverse causes is propelling migration of Nepali labour, brain, business and capital.

Availability of life-saving basics and opportunity within the nation can retain them and commit them to national purpose. But it requires exploring a wider range of inquiry, options and possibilities, inspiring those responsible to improve the condition of life and make the nation livable and lovable again.

Leaders, educational policy wonks, business, administration and the people can do it collectively and open conversation with every one interested in repairing creaky knowledge production, management and intergenerational transfer so that national gains a spur of confidence. This means national leaders have to yearn to make a difference by changing structural, policy and culture of education.

Stability of Nepali democracy merits solidarity between educational leaders, students and the people, their engagement in crafting reforms of education so that the nation does not face a false choice between status quo and frequent unpredictable leap of student and teachers unions into agitational politics.

Autonomy of educational institutions, recruitment of best teachers and valuing trust in self, one's own ability, enthusiasm, strength of collective vision for quality education can unburden the necessities of life and incubate possibilities for overall progress. It requires lending hands by family, society, the nation and global fraternity and translating the vision of education to make students good citizens. Prospects of egalitarian society underlined in the constitution are achievable with a massive dose of investment in the nation's public and community education system where private education can complement.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Power Of Written Word

EZEQUIEL MORSELLA

The everyday stimulus of the written word can reliably and insuppressibly activate two conscious contents. How words activate conscious contents reveals much about the nature of consciousness and the brain. The conscious field encompasses everything that one is aware of, and is experiencing, at one moment in time. For example, right now, as I am typing, I am aware of my computer, the smell of coffee, and the sound of birds outside my window, among other things. Each thing one is conscious of, at one moment in time, is a conscious content. The conscious field is composed of all the concurrently activated conscious contents.

Stimuli often activate conscious contents, such as memories. When discussing this with my lab, the question arose: Can one single stimulus reliably activate, not one, but two separate conscious contents? Right away we started designing possible experiments to investigate this possibility. We considered a laboratory study in which a single stimulus (e.g., an abstract shape) could, after some training that occurred earlier in the laboratory, activate two separate conscious contents (e.g., an olfactory memory and a visual memory).

The idea was that subjects could learn to associate a stimulus with two conscious experiences and then, after enough training, the stimulus by itself could activate these associations. As an experimenter, one becomes accustomed to thinking in terms of "experimental manipulations" and "control conditions" in order to test some hypothesis. But a few days after the discussion, I realised that no such experiment is necessary, as there already exists a stimulus that reliably and insuppressibly activates two different kinds of conscious content: the written word. It sure is a "super stimulus."

When one is presented with a written word (HOUSE), one cannot help but read it. Reading the word is no trivial process. It involves (at the least) activating visual centres in the brain, such that one can identify, say, the font in which the word is written, and involves activating the phonological representation of the word, which is an auditory-based mental representation associated with auditory areas of the brain (e.g., the superior temporal sulcus). Thus, a single written word can reliably and insuppressibly activate two different kinds of mental representations (one based on vision and one on audition), involving different brain areas and yielding two separate conscious contents, each of which is activated insuppressibly.

Words also activate meaning. These "semantic" representations might differ more among individuals than the lower-level visual and auditory representations activated by a written word. Thus, experimentally, this would make it difficult to know exactly what was activated, meaning-wise, in a subject presented with the word BIRTHDAY, for example. But the visual representation and phonological representation are more likely to be similar across subjects.

Importantly, such activations are "high-level" and insuppressible, and result from years and years of extensive training. (Reading is not natural or inborn.) What makes this effect even more striking is that the association between the sound of a word (e.g., /haus/) and how it is written (e.g., HOUSE) is arbitrary and based only on convention. And we have so many of these mappings. The average college student has over 40,000 of these mappings between written words (an "orthograph") and their phonologies, and this is counting only one language.

This mapping, and the resulting insuppressible activations in consciousness, are an incredible feat of the human brain. It is hard to think of any other animal that can store in its knowledge centres 50,000 such arbitrary mappings, not to mention the many more mappings that exist outside of reading, such as between objects and their names, which, too, involves an arbitrary mapping (the same object has different names across languages).

The lab and I were surprised that the most impressive experimental effect, one with far-reaching implications, is one that happens all the time in everyday life. What's more, no laboratory experiment can ever involve a training session that is as elaborate and extensive as that for learning how to read. (Other interesting cases are musical notation and simple arithmetic.) This skill requires extensive training, but after the training, everything becomes automatic and almost effortless.

The skill then elicits conscious contents, reliably and insuppressibly. Reading reveals so much about how conscious contents are usually activated by external stimuli. My lab and I did need to recruit any subjects to study this interesting effect. It is occurring all the time, for free. For now, I leave you with this. Please do not read the following phrase: HAPPY HOLIDAYS.

-- Psychology Today

Premature Babies Can Live Normal, Healthy Life

Laxmi Bhandari



The premature baby's world was completely unknown to me until I joined a neonatal unit in a UK hospital in 2018. Babies are normally born at 40 weeks of post menstrual age, however, due to various complications during pregnancy including various maternal and medical conditions, around 15 million babies are born prematurely around the globe. The World Prematurity Day is celebrated around the world to raise awareness about premature births and its huge impact on families.

Most people are unaware that babies born at even 22 weeks can survive if they receive advanced neonatal care in a tertiary level neonatal unit. As per BAPM Framework 2019, only three babies survive out of 10 born at 22 weeks, four babies survive out of 10 if they are born at 23 weeks. The chance of survival and associated medical conditions are better if babies are born after 26 weeks of gestation. The disability rate is also high in the extremely premature babies (22-26 weeks of gestational age). Prior to birth, antenatal steroids are offered to mothers to reduce the risk of breathing problems, and prevent bleeding into the brain, all of this can reduce the risk of developmental delays.

Crucial care

The nursing and medical care at the early age of life is very crucial to determine the survival rate, as well as to promote positive growth and development of the newborn. The chance of survival and long-term outcomes will depend on the gestational age as discussed previously but also on other risk factors such as growth restriction, foetal abnormalities, antenatal steroids, management at birth and risk factor for infection. The most common health condition which specifically affects these vulnerable preterm infants is chronic lungs disease, patent ductus arteriosus, respiratory distress syndrome, retinopathy of prematurity, bronchopulmonary dysplasia, intraventricular haemorrhage, necrotising enterocolitis, sepsis, prolonged jaundice, anaemia of prematurity and gastro-oesophageal reflux.

Giving birth to a premature baby is extremely stressful and devastating to the parents because they are worried about the long-term health outcomes and frightened with the wires and breathing tubes along with intravenous lines on their tiny baby. All parents wish for a perfect and healthy baby at birth. When they see their little babies in the incubator for the first time, they feel very shocked and can be emotional.

> Family centred care is prioritised to achieve optimal outcomes. Parents are seen as partners in care, and the expert on their baby's needs.

Initially parents can feel very scared to touch and provide cares to their babies, since they are worried their baby is small and delicate. They can find it difficult to care for their babies needs and feel confident handling. To overcome this, parent need continuous support, and updates about their babies on regular basis and encouragement to participate in the treatment plan made by medical and nursing team. Family centred care is prioritised to achieve optimal outcomes. Parents are seen as partners in care, and the expert on their baby's needs.

The positive news is that most of the preterm babies are truly fighter as many of them will normalise at 37-42 weeks of corrected gestational age and will be ready to go home. Most of the parents will spend a few days and nights with their babies at the neonatal unit immediately prior to the discharge, to build up their confidence to look after their babies.

Parental role

Discharge advice is provided to parents to prevent any incident, and basic life support in case of an at home emergency. All vitamins and medications are prepared and given to parents before discharge. Parents can demonstrate a mix of emotion during the discharge. On the one side they are immensely happy to take their baby home, and on the other, they are worried about the baby's cares and safety at home. Babies are seen by consultant in the community to monitor their growth and development. Most of the babies live normal healthy life like other full-term babies.

(The author is a nurse at the UK-based West Hertfordshire Hospital.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 23, 1973

Petrol Rationing In Biratnagar

Biratnagar, Dec. 22: The regional office of Nepal Oil Corporation here is to ration out petrol and control its consumption in Biratnagar and Dharan by means of coupon system, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Emulate Karnali Provincial Hospital



This is regarding the news report "*Karnali Provincial Hospital introduces online OPD tickets*" published in this daily on Dec. 22. According to the report, the Karnali Provincial Hospital in Surkhet has introduced online booking system for OPD patients, meaning that people no longer need to stand in long queues for doctor's appointment.

To make things sweeter, patients can now register online and select the doctors, date and appointment time. Surely, this new service will go a long way to make things easier for them. Karnali province had remained backward in almost every indicator for long, but this remarkable progress shows things are changing for the better.

Even notable hospitals in urban areas lack such facilities, forcing patients to stand in long lines. This wastes critical time of the patients and lead to delay in getting treatment. And delay can result in the worst nightmare. If all hospitals emulate the hospital in question, it would be much better.

Kapil Basyal
Texas, USA

TAILPIECE

One afternoon in the Arctic, a father polar bear and his son polar bear were sitting in the snow. The son polar bear turned to his father and asked, "Dad, am I 100% polar bear?"

"Of course, son, you're 100% polar bear."

A few minutes pass, and the son polar bear turns to his father again and says, "Dad, tell me the truth. I can take it. Am I 100% polar bear? No brown bear or panda bear or grizzly bear?"

"Son, I'm 100% polar bear and your mother is 100% polar bear, so you're certainly 100% polar bear."

A few more minutes pass, and the son polar bear again turns to his father and says, "Dad, don't think your sparing my feelings if it's not true. I really need to know... am I really 100% polar bear?"

Distressed by this continued questioning, the father polar bear finally asked his son, "Why do you keep asking if you're 100% polar bear?"

"Because I'm freezing to death out here!"

14 people killed in Prague university shooting



PHOTO: AP

A mourner lays a candle light outside the building of Philosophical Faculty of Charles University for victims of mass shooting in Prague, Czech Republic, Friday, Dec. 22, 2023.

AP
Prague, Dec. 22

Three foreign nationals were among 25 wounded after a student opened fire at a university in the Czech capital, Prague, killing 14 people, authorities said Friday. The mass shooting was one of the Czech Republic's worst attacks in recent years.

Minister Vit Rakusan said police in Prague worked overnight and 13 of those killed have been identified. He also said three of those wounded were foreigners — two from Saudi Arabia and one from the Netherlands.

The bloodshed took place on Thursday at the Faculty of Arts of Charles University, where the 24-year-old shooter was a student, Prague Police Chief Martin Vondrasek said. The gunman also died, authorities said. His name has not been released.

Authorities warned that the death toll could rise.

Early Friday, with the scene of the shooting still sealed off by the police, people could be seen lighting candles to mourn the victims at an impromptu vigil by the university headquarters.

Police said Friday they have boosted security at schools and other "soft targets" — usually public facilities that are difficult to secure — in a preventive measure. University rectors also said they would work with police experts on more preventive measures to increase security around campus.

Police have so far given no details about the victims or a possible motive for the shooting at the building located near the Vltava River in Jan Palach Square. Rakusan said Thursday that investigators didn't suspect a link to any extremist ideology or groups.

Officials said they believed he had no accomplice.

Vondrasek, the police chief, said they believe the gunman killed his father earlier on Thursday in his hometown of Hostoun, just west of Prague, and that he had also been planning to kill himself. He also said the gunman was suspected of killing a man and his 2-month-old daughter on Dec. 15, in Prague.

The chief described the shooter as an excellent student with no criminal record. He said the gunman suffered "devastating injuries" but it was not clear if he killed himself or was shot and killed by the police in an exchange of fire.

Police said the shooter had legally owned several guns — based on his home search — and that he was heavily armed during the attack.

Charles Univeristy issued a statement earlier mourning "the loss of life."

Leaders from many countries, including the United States, and the U.N Secretary-General conveyed their condolences.

Sudan fighting displaces 7 million people



PHOTO: AFP

Displaced people fleeing from Wad Madani in Sudan's Al-Jazira state arrive in Gedaref in the country's east on December 19, 2023.

AFP
Sudan, Dec. 22

More than seven million people have been displaced by fighting in Sudan, the United Nations said on Thursday as more displaced people continued to flee a former safe haven.

"According to the International Organization for Migration, up to 300,000 people have fled Wad Madani in Al-Jazira state in a new wave of large-scale displacement," UN secretary-general's spokesman Stephane Dujarric said.

Another 1.5 million people have fled to neighbouring countries, he added.

"These latest movements will push Sudan's displacement population to 7.1 million people, the world's largest displacement crisis," Dujarric said.

More than half a million people had found shelter in Al-Jazirah, Sudan's prewar breadbasket, before the fighting engulfed the state capital, Wad Madani.

In a bitter reminder of the first days of war in Khartoum, those who had tried to make a home in Wad Madani saw the city overrun by the same violence they hoped they had left behind.

The International Committee of the Red Cross, which pulled out its staff last week as fighting reached the city, appealed for "life-saving access to all areas affected by fighting as humanitarian needs soar".

"Our colleagues in Sudan have heard bone-chilling stories of the harrowing journeys women and children were forced to make just to reach the safety of Madani city," said the head of UNICEF, the UN children's agency, Catherine Russell.

That's the number of children forcibly displaced in less than a week as fighting escalates in Sudan's Al Jazirah state. "Now, even that fragile sense of security is shattered as those same children have once again been forced from their homes.

No child should have to experience the horrors of war. Children, and the civilian infrastructure they rely on, must be protected." By early December, the war between the army and the RSF had killed 12,190 people, according to a conservative estimate by the Armed Conflict Locations and Event Data project.

Vatican prosecutor appeals cardinal's fraud case verdict

AP
Vatican City, Dec. 22

The Vatican's chief prosecutor has appealed a court verdict that largely dismantled his theory of a grand conspiracy to defraud the Holy See of millions of euros but found a cardinal guilty of embezzlement.

Prosecutor Alessandro Diddi filed his appeal earlier this week, days after the three-judge tribunal issued its verdict in a complicated financial trial that aired the Vatican's dirty laundry and tested the peculiar legal system in an absolute monarchy in the center of Europe.

While the headline from Saturday's verdict focused on Cardinal Angelo Becciu's 5 ½-year sentence for embezzlement, the meat of the ruling made clear that the judges rejected most of Diddi's 487-page indictment.

Diddi had accused Becciu and nine other people of dozens of counts of fraud, embezzlement, money laundering, extortion, corruption, abuse of office and witness tampering in connection with the Vatican's bungled investment in a London property.

He had sought prison terms of up to 13 years apiece and 400 million euros in restitution. In the end, the tribunal headed by Judge Giuseppe Pignatone acquitted one of the defendants entirely and convicted the others of only a few of the charges they faced, while still ordering them to pay some 366 million euros in restitution.

In the Vatican, as in Italy, prosecutors can appeal verdicts at the same time as defendants. Unlike Italy, both sides must file appeals even before the trial judge issues his written motivations explaining the verdicts, though they can amend them, lawyers said.

In this case, Diddi filed a three-page motion on Dec. 19 asking the Vatican appeals court to convict each defendant for the full set of charges that he originally laid out, even though the tribunal ruled that many of the alleged crimes simply didn't occur.

The main focus of the trial involved the Holy See's 350 million euro investment in converting a former Harrod's warehouse into luxury apartments.

Diddi alleged brokers and Vatican monsignors fleeced the Holy See of tens of millions of euros in fees and commissions, and then extorted the Holy See for 15 million euros ($16.5 million) to cede control of the property.

Becciu, the first cardinal prosecuted by the Vatican criminal tribunal, was convicted of embezzlement involving the original London investment and two tangent cases.

The broker who received the 15 million euro payout to cede control of the building, Gianluigi Torzi, was convicted of extortion and other charges.

US leads mission to safeguard Red Sea shipping



AFP
Gaza, Dec. 22

The Iran-backed Houthis have repeatedly targeted vessels in the vital shipping lane with strikes they say are in support of Palestinians in Gaza, where Israel is battling militant group Hamas. "We've had over 20 nations now sign on to participate" in the coalition, Pentagon spokesman Major General Pat Ryder told journalists.

Ryder said the Houthis are "attacking the economic wellbeing and prosperity of nations around the world," effectively becoming "bandits along the international highway that is the Red Sea."

Coalition forces will "serve as a highway patrol of sorts, patrolling the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden to respond to – and assist as necessary – commercial vessels that are transiting this vital international waterway," he said, calling on the Houthis to cease their attacks.

The latest round of the Israel-Hamas conflict began when the Palestinian militant group carried out a shock cross-border attack on October 7 that killed around 1,140 people in Israel, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Vowing to destroy Hamas, Israel began a relentless bombardment of targets in Gaza, alongside a ground invasion, which Gaza's Hamas government on Wednesday said has killed at least 20,000 people.

Those deaths have provoked widespread anger in the Middle East and provided an impetus for attacks by armed groups in the region, including the Houthi strikes on Red Sea shipping.

The United States announced the multinational Red Sea coalition on Monday, while the Houthis warned two days later that they would strike back if attacked.

PRISM

Officials share video of flying deer

Utah: The Utah Division of Wildlife Resources shared a video of some unusual flying deer -- but they aren't pulling Santa's sleigh.

The DWR posted a video to Facebook showing a helicopter being used to relocate three deer at a time in the skies over the state.

"These aren't Santa's flying reindeer! Each winter, our biologists capture and place GPS collars on approximately 1,200 deer throughout the state," the post said.

The DWR said the deer are brought to a staging area for health assessments before being returned to their habitats.

Man runs marathon in football uniform

Texas: A Texas man decided to support his favorite football team by running a marathon in a full uniform -- and setting a world record.

Brian Goldsmith donned a full football uniform representing the Arlington Renegades, the XFL team he works for as a ticket rep, and ran the Dallas Marathon with a time of 3 hours, 29 minutes and 30 seconds.

Goldsmith beat the previous record for fastest marathon dressed in an American football kit (male), which was set at 3 hours, 33 minutes and 42 seconds by Australian man Alistair Kealty in 2019.

"I've wanted to be in the Guinness World Record book for a really long time, have a couple failed attempts," Goldsmith told WFAA-TV.

(AP)

China air pollution worsens in 2023

AFP
Beijing, Dec. 22



PHOTO: AFP

China's air pollution worsened in 2023, the first time it has done so in a decade.

China's air pollution worsened in 2023, the first time it has done so in a decade, a study released on Friday said.

"2023 is the first year that China's national average PM2.5 level has increased year-on-year since the beginning of China's 'war on pollution' in 2013," a study by independent research organisation the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA) said.

PM2.5 particles, if inhaled, can have serious health risks, linked to premature deaths in people with heart or lung disease, as well as a host of breathing and other health issues, according to the US Environmental Protection Agency.

"The overall increase in human-caused emissions has pushed the pollution level higher, in addition to unfavourable weather conditions," CREA said.

An international consortium of climate scientists said earlier this month in a separate study that China is expected to see a four percent rise in fossil fuel CO2 emissions this year, with increases in coal, oil and gas as the country continues to rebound from its Covid-19 lockdowns.

Chinese cities including the capital Beijing were once infamous for the thick smog that smothered their residents, especially in winter.

But the country ramped up its anti-pollution campaign after winning the Winter Olympics bid in 2015, shutting down dozens of coal plants and relocating heavy industries.

That has brought significant improvements, but air quality often remains below World Health Organization standards.

CREA said on Friday that 80 percent of provincial capitals, including Beijing, recorded increased PM2.5 levels in 2023 compared to a year ago.

"Coal production and thermal power production in areas where the PM2.5 standard was not met have increased by 4.4 percent and 4.3 percent, respectively, on year, indicating a larger use of fossil energy," the Finland-based independent research organisation said.

CREA based its findings on Chinese government data, as well as a machine-learning algorithm that distinguished between the impact of weather and human emissions.

A wave of severe pollution hit northern China in late October and November, with authorities warning residents to avoid outdoor activities.

Beijing's concentrations of hazardous PM 2.5 particles were more than 20 times higher than World Health Organisation guidelines during that period, according to air quality monitoring firm IQAir.

China is the world's biggest emitter of the greenhouse gases driving climate change, such as carbon dioxide.

A recent jump in approvals for coal-fired power plants has added to concerns that China will backtrack on its goals to peak emissions between 2026 and 2030 and become carbon-neutral by 2060.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1815 – The novel Emma by Jane Austen is first published.
1876 – First day of the Constantinople Conference which resulted in agreement for political reforms in the Balkans.
1893 – The opera Hansel and Gretel by Engelbert Humperdinck is first performed.
1913 – The Federal Reserve Act is signed into law by President Woodrow Wilson, creating the Federal Reserve System.
1970 – The Democratic Republic of the Congo officially becomes a one-party state.
1972 – A 6.5 magnitude earthquake strikes the Nicaraguan capital of Managua killing more than 10,000.
1972 – The 16 survivors of the Andes flight disaster are rescued after 73 days, surviving by cannibalism.
2015 – A bomb explodes at Istanbul's Sabiha Gökçen Airport, killing one airport cleaner. The Kurdistan Freedom Hawks claim responsibility for the attack four days later.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURNNG/TRN

Chariot procession of Goddess Indrayani is being taken out in Kirtipur on Friday. It is a part of three day long festival of seven villages of the area.

PM Prachanda hints at cabinet reshuffling

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Urlabari, Dec. 22

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that he was working in favour of good governance and social justice.

Addressing a programme called, 'Maoist with People: A Campaign for Special Transformation' held at Kholitar, Miklajung-5 in Morang on Friday, Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chairman Prachanda said so.

He said the government was playing an important role in promoting Nepal's reputation at the national and international levels.

He said, "As my tenure of one year as the Prime Minister of the country for the third time draws to a close, I intend to address the nation and its people on the day marking the completion of my year-long tenure."

Every detail will be mentioned in my address, he added.

Expressing his commitment to addressing the nation on December 26 and prioritising the people's concerns starting from December 27, he said he would call the ministers at Singha Durbar to closely examine their works.

Certain ministries have not performed up to satisfactory standards, he said adding, "We aim to expedite the work even by restructuring these ministries and changing ministers."

Stating that he was well aware of the concerns and sentiments of the people in Koshi Province regarding identity and the province's name, he expressed commitment to take the initiative to address this matter positively by engaging in dialogue with leaders from all the protesting organisations.

He expressed, "Addressing the issues of this area as the Prime Minister brings me immense happiness. During the 'People's War', this area was the base region of Morang district."

Prime Minister Prachanda reaffirmed his dedication to completing the Lavakhola water supply project.

He also pledged to advance the development plans for Chulachuli, Miklajung, and Letang roads, vowing to expedite work on the incomplete roads in Urlabari, Madhumalla, and Daregounda.

Prime Minister Prachanda highlighted his intention to take the initiative in resolving the issue of landless squatters in Pathari Shanishchare and to offer concessional loans to dairy development organisations, aiming to support farmers in selling their milk at better prices.

In teh same event, Dinesh Paudel, executive chairman of Miklajung Rural Municipality, presented a memorandum to Prime Minister Prachanda.

'Strengthen accountability systems for aid effectiveness'

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

Policy stakeholders, including lawmakers, senior economists and experts have called for strengthening national accountability systems for aid effectiveness in Nepal.

At a launch of 'An assessment of foreign aid effectiveness: Sources, use and development' hosted by ActionAid International Nepal in the capital on Friday, speakers said foreign aid has spectacular role in the country having reform-oriented governments to address socio-economic needs and anchor overhaul in multiple sectors.

In his address to the event, Speaker of the House of Representatives (HoR), Dev Raj Ghimire, stressed measuring foreign aid effectiveness in a relative manner as it has helped address several national priorities.

"Comprehensive analysis with empirical evidences is required to claim the extent of effectiveness of foreign aid in translating national priorities into action", he said, adding foreign aid, in its any forms and natures, should be accepted and spent aligning the stipulated national priorities to make the country self-reliant, and reduce socio-economic inequalities and backwardness.

The Speaker also highlighted the urgency of ensuring general people's access to foreign aid in an equitable manner for which parliament is an effective mechanism.

Rendering comment on the study report, former minister Dr Minendra Rijal said governance loopholes should be fixed first to enable environment for effective aid spending and its outcomes. "Until and unless national systems perform well, foreign aid cannot be instrumental in financing socio-economic transformation of the country", he noted.

Also speaking on the occasion, economist Dr Swarnim Wagle suggested drawing evidences on the effectiveness of remittances, taxes and foreign direct investment in addressing the country needs since these sources have higher share in the country's Gross Domestic Production (GDP).

"Foreign aid contributes five percent to the GDP, so let us not create a narrative to make foreign actor the change agent of our economic architecture", he said, underscoring enlightened conditionality while negotiating with bilateral and multilateral development partners for foreign aid.

Former finance minister Dr Yubaraj Khatiwada said foreign aid has helped Nepal in advancing several social reforms and welfare gains, so it should not be merely analyzed from economic dividends. "The country system should receive aid in a way to cater to the national plans, policies and priorities. We should also see the global power balance and geopolitics while accepting foreign aid as a vital instrument of development", Dr Khatiwada suggested.

Feminist economist and GESI expert Bharati Silwal said as Nepal was recognized as a global leader in introducing gender-responsive budgeting, sustainability of such innovative measures had always been a big question.

Calling for strong compliance to ensure aid harmonization and mutual accountability of receivers and donors, she also laid emphasis on adequate engagement of civil society organizations, including feminists in designing and delivering aid and budget spending measures.

Presenting the study findings, economist Dr Dilli Raj Khanal said enhancement of aid effectiveness cannot be enhanced without bold reforms in the structural, institutional and governance fronts. "Aid alignment is simply referred to development plans. How mutual accountability systems can be enhanced without outlining how the federal systems will be used to bring about required transformation in the economy with the support of development partners."

Khanal is the author of the report.

The study has highlighted gaps between the existing aid policy provisions and implementation gaps. "There is hardly any linkage between the aid policies and aid effectiveness agenda as revealed by the comparative analysis of trends between the aid and some selected direct and proxy indices", it was shared as findings.

Executive Director of ActionAid International Nepal, Sujeeta Mathema said the study was commissioned to assess the aid effectiveness in Nepal in light of aid policies and also in cognizant of the broad consensus at international level that the assistance has to be country-led, result-oriented, inclusive and transparent.

Sudurpaschim Province will be made child-friendly: CM Shah

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhangadhi, Dec. 22

Chief Minister of Sudurpaschim Province Kamal Bahadur Shah has said that the Provincial government was working to make Sudurpaschim a child-friendly province.

Accepting a memorandum submitted by the children at the Office of the Chief Minister and the Council of Ministers on Friday, CM Shah said that there might be some delay in creating a child-friendly environment but the Provincial government will surely implement the commitment.

CM Shah said that the provincial government was ready to implement the rights ensured by the Constitution and also asked the civil organisations to cooperate by paying attention to the spirit of the Constitution.

It is mentioned in the memorandum that 20.9 per cent of children are working as child labourers in Sudurpaschim Province, and among them, 1.4 per cent of children are involved in hazardous work.

According to the conclusions drawn by the children of Kailali and Dadeldhura, who participated in the three-day workshop held in Dhangadhi for the capacity building of youth and children under the projects of Freedom Campaign and Faya Nepal, concluded that Juvenile Courts in all districts in the province, formation of child rights committees at the local levels as per the Children's Act, 2078, establishment of children fund and enlistment of social workers and child psychologists, be managed in the province.

The provincial government has provided special grants to the local levels that are committed to child labour-free local levels within the province. Each local level needs to declare a child labour-free municipality, creating an action plan with programmes to end child-labour, operating and rehabilitating rescued child labourers at the provincial level.

The children have also asked the budget for rescue, temporary protection and rehabilitation services for the institution working in the child sector.

Stop youth migration: Lamichhane

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Dec. 22

President of Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) Ravi Lamichhane has said that youth are forced to migrate abroad owing to increased corruption and poverty in the country.

Addressing a meeting held at Bhimad Bazaar in Bhimad Municipality of Tanahun on Friday, President Lamichhane said that the country was facing financial crisis due to corruption and when youths were not getting opportunities in the country.

The main agenda of the party is to combat corruption and create job opportunities to retain youths in the country, he said.



Lamichhane claimed that his party would open the files of corruption by winning the majority in the 2027 election. He said that he had to face lawsuits and challenges from all sectors when he was involved in the campaign to end corruption when he was the Home Minister.

The present government tried to open the corruption files but was compelled to close them after the names of their party leaders surfaced in those corruption cases, claimed Lamichhane.

He said that he was exhilarated by the people's support in the move to end corruption. He stressed that his party was fighting for the rights of women.

Lamichhane said that women should be protected and respected, and they have operated Blue Bus concept to provide public transport services exclusively for women.

He said that the Blue Bus service would be gradually expanded throughout the country.

Political leaders in need of moral culture: Koirala

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Barahachhetra, Dec. 22

Nepali Congress leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala has said that the leadership of the political parties has lost their moral power.

Speaking at a meeting of the party workers and an interaction programme organised by the NC Sunsari District Committee in Inaruwa on Friday, Dr. Koirala said people's frustration was increasing against the present governance system because of the anarchical expressions of the ministers.

Dr. Koirala said the recent statement given by Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation Minister Sudan Kirati was wrong, and such a statement generated frustration over republicanism and federalism.

He said corruption and impunity were thriving in the country.

"Corruption and impunity are on the rise due to the government's failure to maintain good governance. Frustration is on the rise among people day by day. Not only leaders and civil servants but also the businessmen have been involved in corruption," he said.

He underlined the need for controlling corruption to bring the country's situation on the right track.

Dr. Koirala viewed those who were involved in defeating the official candidates in the name of the faction were not NC. NC central member Rajib Koirala urged the party leadership to correct its past mistakes. Another central member Rajib Dhungana urged the people's representatives associated with the NC to work effectively.

Meanwhile, the NC Jhapa district committee decided to forward party leader Krishna Prasad Sitaula's name as a candidate for the National Assembly member unanimously.

A meeting of the committee held on Friday decided to recommend his name stating that Sitaula should be recognised for his role in peace process, constitution writing and others. NA election is being held on January 25.

NC's Bagmati...

In the conference, coordination and co-work among the three-level governments for their rights and implementation of programmes will also be discussed, Baniya said.

About 800 representatives from the federal parliament constituencies, province assembly constituencies, municipalities and others are participating in the conference.

Hierarchy row was seen in various provincial conferences of the NC. When asked about it, Baniya said his committee would maintain the hierarchy of the leaders based on the party statute and decisions.

3,721 Jajarkot families receive fund to build temporary shelters

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Dec. 22

Ward offices in Jajarkot have started distributing relief assistance to the earthquake victims, whose houses got completely damaged in the quake, for the construction of temporary shelters.

According to the information, 3,721 families have received Rs. 25,000 each as first tranche for the construction of temporary shelters.

Bheri Municipality has confirmed 4,549 as their real beneficiaries eligible for the assistance. After an agreement with 484 families, the local wards have already released Rs. 12 million in the respective account numbers of the beneficiaries.

Maintaining 5,586 total beneficiaries in Barekote, it has distributed Rs. 26.6 million to 1,065 families as the first installment. Similarly, Kushe Rural Municipality has maintained 5,287 as its real beneficiaries. Likewise, Shivalaya Rural Municipality has distributed Rs. 54.3 million in the accounts of 2,172 families out of 3,309 total beneficiaries.

According to Chief District Officer Suresh Sunar, the government has released Rs. 93.02 million for Jajarkot quake victims for the construction of temporary shelters.

SAU to have Chair from Pakistan, President from India

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The Eleventh Meeting of the Governing Board of South Asian University (SAU) held in Kathmandu recently decided to appoint Prof. K. K. Agrawal from India as the new President of SAU.

The Board also agreed to transfer the Chairmanship of the Governing Board to Pakistan, after Nepal, on the principle of rotation in alphabetical order of the Member States, according to a press statement released from the SAARC Secretariat.

It is stated that the meeting also endorsed SAU's budget for 2023-24 and academic calendar for 2024-25.

On the occasion, the Secretary General of SAARC Md. Golam Sarwar said "As the centre of excellence, the University holds great potential to foster socio-economic and cultural collaboration among the South Asian countries."

96th Oscar shortlists announced, Nepal fails to make it

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22



For the 96th Academy Awards, the Nepali film 'Halkara' was submitted as Nepal's representative in the Foreign Language Film category.

The International Film Selection Committee for the Oscars in Nepal had chosen this film as the country's entry for the renowned global award competition.

Unfortunately, as in the past years, the film did not make it to the shortlist.

Directed by Bikram Sapkota, the film starts Mahesh Tripathi and Binita Thapa Magar in the lead roles.

The Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences disclosed shortlists across 10 categories for the upcoming Oscars on Thursday.

Similar to Nepal, no Indian film secured a spot at the Oscars.

The Malayalam film '2018 - Everyone is a Hero', featuring Tovino Thomas in a survival drama, was submitted to the Oscars as India's official entry for the Best Foreign Language Film category, but unfortunately did not make it into the competition.

Last year, the Telugu-language blockbuster hit film 'RRR' directed by SS Rajamouli, achieved a remarkable feat at the Oscars. The popular dance song 'Naatu Naatu' from the film made history by becoming the first Indian film song to win an Oscar.

Likewise, another Indian documentary 'The Elephant Whisperers' won the Best Documentary Short Film in the Oscars.

On the contrary, Bhutan has secured a spot two times. 'The Monk and the Gun' from Bhutan has once again been shortlisted for the Oscars.

Bhutan's entry, 'Lunana: A Yak in the Classroom' made it to the shortlist at the 94th Academy Awards for Best International Feature Film.

The shortlisted categories for Oscar include documentary feature film, documentary short film, international feature film, makeup and hairstyling, music (original score), music (original song), animated short film, live-action short film, sound, and visual effects.

Noteworthy films such as 'Barbie', 'Oppenheimer', 'Killers of the Flower Moon', 'The Color Purple', and 'The Zone of Interest' have earned spots on multiple lists.

The Oscars ceremony is scheduled for March 10 at the Dolby Theatre in Ovation Hollywood and will be broadcast live on ABC.

Jimmy Kimmel is set to return as the host.

Beauticians in Waling engaging in social works

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE
Syangja, Dec. 22



The beauticians in Waling of Syangja district have actively been engaging in social work alongside their business activities.

They organise 'Deusi-Bhailo' programme during the Tihar festival every year and use the funds collected from the cultural programme to support various social causes.

During the Tihar festival this yera, they successfully raised Rs. 100,000 and used it for charitable initiatives.

Pushpa Aryal, the President of the Beauty Parlor Association in Syangja, said that the primary objective of playing 'Deusi-Bhailo' was to contribute to the preservation of religion, culture and tradition.

The collected funds are directed towards impactful social work, demonstrating the beauticians' commitment to both their craft and community, she added.

Aryal highlighted that the beauticians of Waling are dedicated to conveying the message that their involvement extends beyond the realm of beauty services to active participation in social welfare.

Beautician Pamila Gurung said that there are more than 50 beauticians in Waling itself, and they intend to connect all of them with business and social work.

President Aryal said that they provided Rs. 15,000 each for the treatment of Chandra Bahadur Gurung and Shanta BK.

Chandra Bahadur Gurung, who lives in Waling-9, was injured in an accident, and Shanta BK of Waling-13 is suffering from cancer. Gurung worked as a wage earner and is currently undergoing treatment in Pokhara.

President Aryal expressed the association's commitment to assisting others facing difficulties and outlined plans to allocate the remaining funds to install an iron chair for tourists at Bahunthan, a popular tourist spot in Waling- 11.

Durga Thapa, the founding district president of the association, noted that in the previous year, Waling's beauticians played 'Deusi-Bhailo' and contributed materials worth Rs. 80,000 to the Ashram in Keladighat.

Comedian Jo Koy is picked to host the Golden Globes as award season kicks off

AP
New York, Dec. 22

Comedian and actor Jo Koy has been tapped to host the Golden Globes, picked by producers for his "infectious energy and relatable humor."

Koy last year saw his "Easter Sunday" become the first big studio movie with an all-Filipino ensemble. He has released five stand-up specials on Comedy Central and Netflix, including his most recent Netflix special, "Live From The Los Angeles Forum."

The Globes are recovering after scandal and several troubled years, including one without a broadcast. The show will take place on Jan. 7 and will mark Koy's first major award show hosting gig.

"We are thrilled to have Jo host the 81st Annual Golden Globe Awards and bring his infectious energy and relatable humor to kick off Hollywood's award season," said Helen Hoehne, Golden Globes president, in a statement Thursday. "We know Jo is bringing his A-game."

"I've stepped onto a lot of stages around the world in my career, but this one is going to be extra special. I'm so excited to be hosting the Golden Globes this year," said Koy in a statement. "This is that moment where I get to make my Filipino family proud."



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA

Minister for Women, Children, and Senior Citizens Surendra Acharya, actor Rajesh Hamal and others jointly unveiled a collection of poems by author Darshan KC during a programme held in Kathmandu on Friday.

EU ANNOUNCES SHORT FILM COMPETITION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The Delegation of the European Union to Nepal has announced a short film competition targeting the 13th Nepal-EU Film Festival scheduled to be held in March/April next year.

In a press release issued on Friday, the Delegation called for submissions from Nepali filmmakers for the short film competition.

The Delegation of the European Union in Nepal has been organising film festivals for the past twelve years with the primary goal of promoting European films and showcasing European history, culture, and lifestyle to foster a better understanding of Europe in Nepal.

The 13th Edition of the Film Festival will feature a short film competition, open to filmmakers who have completed their films after January 1, 2020.

The submission deadline is set for January 31, 2024.

Submissions in all languages spoken in Nepal are welcome, however, the films should be accompanied by English subtitles, read a press release issued the Delegation of the European Union to Nepal.

Out of the submitted entries, six selected short films will be screened across Nepal as part of the Nepal-EU Film Festival in 2024.

The best film director will be granted the opportunity to travel to Brussels and showcase their film at the Nepali Film Festival in Brussels, Belgium.

Vin Diesel accused of sexual battery by former assistant

AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 22



"Fast and Furious" star Vin Diesel has been accused by his former assistant of sexual battery while working for him in 2010.

Asta Jonasson filed a lawsuit in Los Angeles on Thursday alleging that Diesel forced himself onto her in a hotel suite in Atlanta. The lawsuit alleges she tried to escape from the room after being forced into Diesel's bed, but the actor moved toward her then groped her breasts and kissed her chest.

Diesel attempted to pull down her underwear, causing her to scream as she ran toward the nearby bathroom. He eventually forced her to touch his erect penis and began to masturbate, the suit says.

The lawsuit said Jonasson closed her eyes in fear of angering Diesel any further and wished the assault would end.

Jonasson was fired hours later by Diesel's sister Samantha Vincent, who is also the president of his One Race Productions.

The lawsuit stated that Jonasson felt like she was a "piece of trash" and her self esteem was "demolished."

"It was clear to her that she was being fired because she was no longer useful — Vin Diesel had used her to fulfill his sexual desires and she had resisted his sexual assaults," the suit alleges.

Jonasson is suing Diesel and his company for creating a hostile work environment, negligent supervision and wrongful termination, among her other claims.

"Let me be very clear: Vin Diesel categorically denies this claim in its entirety," attorney Bryan Freedman said in a statement reported by the trade outlet Variety. "This is the first he has ever heard about this more than 13-year-old claim made by a purportedly 9-day employee. There is clear evidence which completely refutes these outlandish allegations."

Jonasson's attorney, Claire-Lise Kutlay, said in a statement that her client's lawsuit seeks to hold Diesel and those who "allowed and covered up his sexual assault, accountable for their egregious actions."

"Employers must protect and defend people when they speak up about sexual assault and harassment," Kutlay said. "We hope Ms. Jonasson's courageous decision to come forward helps create lasting change and empowers other survivors."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: The best approach to life is an open-minded one! The planets are reminding you of this as messenger Mercury retrogrades into your 9th House of Higher Learning.

CANCER: Be sure to check all your work twice, if not three times. Mercury is currently retrograding back into your 6th House of Productivity, making mistakes and missteps as common as potholes on a badly maintained road.

LIBRA: A current of confusion is whirling around your town. Mercury Retrograde is tumbling into your busy 3rd house, which will probably throw a few wrenches in the works of your usual routine.

CAPRICORN: Nothing is what it seems. You can't help but notice when everything feels like it's moving backward, due to Mercury retrograding into your mysterious 12th house.

TAURUS: It's not your imagination, Taurus; things are more intense than usual. There is a good reason for this, though, as Mercury is spinning in reverse into your complex, yet resourceful, 8th house.

LEO: Your past creative endeavors may be worth a second glance. Mental Mercury is backtracking into your artistic 5th house, inspiring you to take your place where everyone can see you.

SCORPIO: Feeling secure in your finances may require more effort than you realize. Your money is demanding your attention as Mercury retrogrades back into your 2nd House of Earnings.

AQUARIUS: Keeping track of people is about as easy as herding cats at present. Your social life is getting shaken up as Mercury retrogrades into your 11th House of Global Connections.

GEMINI: People may currently want a lot from you -- perhaps more than you're willing to give. Your ruler Mercury is retrograding into your 7th House of Cooperation, which could make you feel like your sense of equilibrium.

VIRGO: Things may not flow as smoothly as you would like within your home's walls right now. Your ruler Mercury is backing up into your domestic sector during its current retrograde cycle.

SAGITTARIUS: Watch your mouth, Sag! There's never been a better chance of saying the wrong thing at the wrong time, thanks to Mercury retrograding back into your sign.

PISCES: Back to the drawing board! You may have to rework a few plans or projects, thanks to Mercury retrograding into your 10th House of Business. This trend will return your attention to certain professional matters.

CARTOON

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NSC URGES ORGANIZERS TO INSURE ATHLETES UNDER SPORTS INSURANCE SCHEME

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

The National Sports Council (NSC) has urged organizers of all sports events to insure the participants under the newly introduced Sports Insurance scheme. Organising a press conference at the Council on Friday, NSC member-secretary Tanka Lal Ghising informed that the Nepal Insurance Authority (NIA) has introduced 'Sports Insurance'.

"My first signature after assuming the office as member secretary on November 30, 2021, was on a document that prioritised introducing sports insurance for every athlete. The NIA made the Sports Insurance Policy public on November 29, 2023," said Ghising. The policy has three categories: low risk, normal risk, and high risk based on the respective sport.

Table tennis, soft tennis, tennis, shooting, golf, bodybuilding, and squash are categorized as low-risk sports. Under normal risk sports, Badminton, Cricket, Hockey, Volleyball, Athletics, Dancing, Judo, Gymnastics, Handball, Basketball, Swimming, Sepak Takraw, Weightlifting, Triathlon, Kabaddi, Kho Kho, Ring wrestling, Karate, Taekwondo, Wushu, Boxing, Full-contact karate, Wrestling and Cycling are categorized.

Likewise, High-risk sports include motor and motorcycling sports, Rafting and Canoeing, Climbing, Pentathlon, Bungee jumping and Canyoning, Muay Thai, Mountain running, Ice hockey and Alpine sports, Water sports, Rugby and Football have been listed under risky sports. "There are processes underway to amend the list of the sports in the three categories," said Ghising.

"We have also started reaching out to every sports association to implement the insurance," said Ghising. "Now we have a dedicated insurance policy for athletes. We will do our best to implement it and take the initiative to make the policy better in the upcoming days," Ghising added.

Pokhara confirm top place, Dhangadhi clinch playoff spot



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

Players of Dhangadhi FC and Pokhara Thunders FC in action during Nepal Super League at Dashrath Stadium, Kathmandu, Friday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

A 1-1 tie against Pokhara Thunders Football Club (PTFC) on Friday ensured second-positioned Dhangadhi FC (DFC) a spot in the playoffs of the second edition of the Nepal Super League.

While PTFC's 15 points cannot be challenged, it is now the top team in league matches with four wins, two draws and a loss. However, DFC has qualified for the playoffs mathematically, so its position in the top four might vary.

Despite the first match of Friday between PTFC and DFC saw many chances to score, it ended with a 1-1 draw.

Yves P. Njanga, PTFC's goalie, saved the shot by Fallou Diagne in the fourth minute and cleared the header of Ahmad Hijazi from the goalline in the 33rd minute.

Likewise, PTFC failed to capitalise on the chances in the 10th and 16th minutes as Padam Kumar Tamang's shot went away from the post and Sanjeeb Bista failed to beat Yves in a one-on-one situation respectively.

However, a commotion inside the box prepared the ball for Milan Rai to score in the 42nd minute. DFC was certain of beating Pokhara and earning a spot as the league topper as the team was in the lead until the 90 minutes.

Nevertheless, a cross by Suraj Jeu Thakuri was converted into the equaliser by Moses G. Twum in the final minute before the injury time. The goal helped Pokhara, the first team to qualify for the playoffs, to stay at the top.

On the other hand, as Jhapa FC (JFC), who was in the fourth position with 10 points, lost against last-positioned FC Chitwan (FCC) in the second match on Friday. Jhapa's chance to play in the playoffs will now be decided by the two matches on Saturday.

Despite the win and climbing to the fifth position, Chitwan has no chance for the playoffs. The two matches on Saturday will be the final matches of the league as every team will have played eight matches each.

Chitwan's captain and goalkeeper Bishal Shrestha became the wall for Jhapa as he stopped three major shots on the target, including a penalty from Anjan Bista.

Two other shots came from Samadar Ochilov and substitute Hari Karki in the 63rd and 72nd minutes. For ensuring a clean sheet with quality saves, Bishal was the player of the match in the match Chitwan won with two goals.

A goal by Rafiq Aminu in the seventh minute was enough for Jhapa to intensify pressure on Chitwan for a comeback. Unable to equalise until the 70th minute despite long passes by goalie Stefan Cupic, Jhapa started pressuring more. Jhapa created chances, but could not go past Bishal.

Meanwhile, the decision to send all defenders ahead as Cupic was shooting long passes to the opponent's side backfired as Aminu got a chance to counter-run with the ball in the open half of Jhapa in the 77th minute and score the second. After the devastating loss, Jhapa's chance for the playoffs hangs by a thread.

Sixth-positioned Kathmandu Rayzrs FC (9 points in 7 matches) is facing Lalitpur City FC (10 points) in the afternoon and Birgunj United FC (8 points) is playing against FC Butwal Lumbini (7 points) on Saturday evening.

A win, which will be difficult, will guarantee a spot in the top four for title-defender Kathmandu. Lalitpur would then have to wait for the evening match between two Tarai teams. Birgunj would have to win with a margin of at least three goals for a chance.

Nevertheless, there are still chances of Lalitpur and Butwal winning or the matches ending in a draw. The final whistle of the second match on Saturday will confirm the teams in the two vacant spots in the top four.

Victory for Koshi, Gandaki, APF and Sudurpashchim



PHOTO:TRN

Players of Koshi Province reacts after winning the Prime Minister Women's T20 Cricket match against Bagmati Province at Kirtipur on Friday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Armed Police Force Club (APF) and Sudurpashchim Province emerged victorious on the second day of the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament 2080 on Friday.

Koshi won against Bagmati, Gandaki defeated Karnali, Madhesh was outclassed by APF and Sudurpashchim emerged victorious against Lumbini.

Bagmati posted a target of 88 for Koshi by losing eight wickets in the 20-over game. Koshi scored 92 in 18.1 overs by losing only two wickets and grabbed their second win in a row.

Both Kajal Shrestha and Apsara Begam, who also took two wickets by giving only nine runs, scored 41 runs each for Koshi. Apsara was also great with the bowl as she picked two wickets.

Meanwhile, Gandaki was able to defend the target against Karnali and won by 44 runs. Karnali, chasing a target of 142, lost six wickets to score only 97 in 20 overs. Anjali Bishwakarma and Jyotsnika Marasaini both scored half-centuries for Gandaki to set the target losing six wickets.

Title defender APF was the most dominant team on Friday as it packed Madhesh in 40 runs in 19.2 overs. APF's openers Jyoti Pandey (16) and Sita Rana Magar (19) scored 41 in 5.5 overs to win the match by 10 wickets. With two consecutive victories, APF topped the league table with four points bettering Koshi on net run rate.

Sudurpashchim Province also showed the team was good with both bat and ball. Restricting Lumbini to 71 in the loss of seven wickets at the end of the 20-over inning, Sudurpashchim's batters won the game in 9.5 overs by nine wickets.

Staying not out at 24 runs in 12 balls and 17 runs in 25 balls, Kabita Joshi and Rewati Dhami chased the target for Sudurpashchim respectively.

Madhesh, Lumbini, Karnali and Bagmati will be playing against Koshi, APF, Sudurpashchim and Gandaki on Sunday respectively.

Real Madrid back in Spanish league lead

AP
Madrid, Dec. 22

With a late goal after a lackluster performance, Real Madrid found its way to victory and to the top of the Spanish league standings.

Lucas Vázquez scored with a header in stoppage-time and Madrid pulled off a 1-0 win on the road against Alaves to reclaim first place after Girona conceded a late equalizer in its 1-1 draw at Real Betis earlier on Thursday.

Madrid and Girona are tied on 45 points but Madrid was ahead on a tiebreaker. Defending champion Barcelona was third, seven points off the lead. The Catalan club edged last-place Almeria 3-2 at home on Wednesday.

Madrid got the late win despite playing with 10 men from the 54th minute after central defender Nacho Fernández was sent off with a straight red card for a hard foul.

"It was a complicated match, and with a player down everybody thought that maybe today we were going to lose," Madrid coach Carlo Ancelotti said. "But this team finds energy out of nowhere. We held tough and in the end we got rewarded."

Vázquez was left free inside the area to score the winner with a header after a well-placed corner-kick cross by Toni Kroos.



It was the third loss in a row for Alaves, which is sitting in 16th place, three points clear from the relegation zone.

Elsewhere, Girona opened the scoring with a penalty kick converted by Artem Dovbyk in the 39th, but the hosts equalized with Germán Pezzella in the 88th after a loose ball inside the area.

Sixth-place Sociedad couldn't manage more than a 0-0 draw at relegation-threatened Cadiz.

Palace and Brighton draw

The Premier League's hectic festive schedule was launched Thursday with another 1-1 draw between rivals Crystal Palace and Brighton, for whom Danny Welbeck grabbed an 82nd-minute equalizer at Selhurst Park.

Welbeck, a second-half substitute, rose to meet Pascal Gross' inswinging cross with a looping header that found the top corner.

That canceled out Jordan Ayew's opener in the first minute of first-half stoppage time that arose from a mistake by Brighton goalkeeper Bart Verbruggen. The Dutch keeper's weak clearance went straight to Michael Olise, who headed to Will Hughes and received the ball back before crossing for Ayew to head home.

It meant Brighton conceded for a 22nd straight league game — the club's longest ever run without a clean sheet.

It was a fifth straight 1-1 draw between the teams at Selhurst Park.



WIndies win T20 series from England

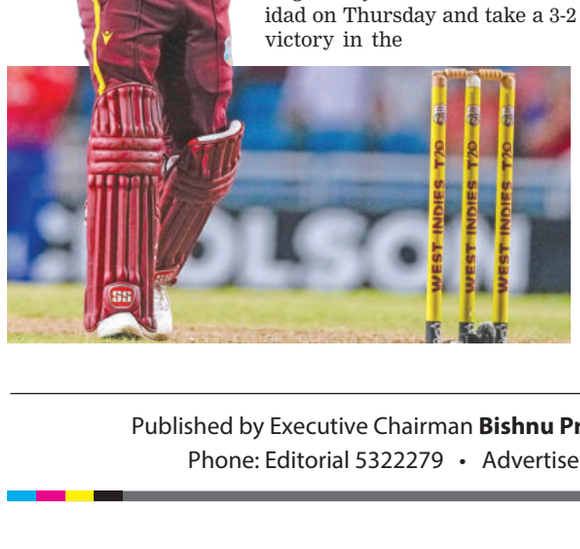
REUTERS/AP
Trinidad, Dec. 22

Shai Hope hit a winning six as West Indies bounced back from defeat earlier in the week to beat England by four wickets in Trinidad on Thursday and take a 3-2 victory in the T20 international series.

The hosts went into the last over chasing nine runs to win but Jason Holder secured three off Chris Woakes' first delivery and Hope then smashed the rest off the next ball at the Brian Lara Cricket Academy in Tarouba. Sam Curran had given England a chance in the previous over, giving away only two runs and taking a wicket.

"It was closer than we thought at the end today, yes. We kept losing key wickets but we always knew Shai Hope was going to be the important man on this pitch," said West Indies captain Rovman Powell.

The victory with four balls to spare completed a hat-trick of T20 series wins for West Indies in 2023 after beating South Africa away and India at home. Hope was the match top scorer with 43 off 43 balls. England were all out for 132 with three deliveries to spare after a late collapse to some stunning bowling and fielding by the home side.



India clinch ODI series

Sanju Samson's maiden hundred in his 16th ODI helped India beat South Africa by 78 runs in the series deciding third game on Thursday.

Samson, promoted to number three, scored 108 runs off 114 balls as India finished with 296-8 in 50 overs. Tilak Varma scored 52 runs.

In response, South Africa was bowled out for 218 runs in 45.5 overs. Left-arm pacer Arshdeep Singh picked 4-30 in nine overs, while off-spinner Washington Sundar took 2-38.

Tony de Zorzi followed his century in the previous game with 81 runs, but he had little support from other batters. India had won the first game in Johannesburg before the Proteas equalized in Gqeberha.

SNIPPETS

Praful, Rashila into semis

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal Army Club's Praful Maharjan and Rasila Maharjan have entered the semifinals of the 2nd Lalitpur Mayor's Cup National Badminton Tournament on Friday. In men's singles, Praful defeated APF Club's Devraj Rana 21-7, 21-6 and in women's singles, Rasila defeated APF's Sunayana Mukhia 21-12, 21-10 to enter the semis.

Praful will face Nepal Police Club's Bishnu Katuwal to enter the finals. Bishnu defeated Army's Abhay Mahara 21-11, 21-15 to secure a meeting with Praful. Similarly, Rasila will compete with Army's Rehna Sherchan in the semis. Rehna overcame Ayushma Nepal of Pokhara Badminton Club 21-10, 21-13.

Likewise, Nepal Police's Jeevan Acharya defeated Army's Roshan Saud 21-7, 21-16 to secure a semis date with APF's Prince Dahal, who ousted Army's David Thapa Magar 21-14, 21-10.

Army's Anumaya Rai and Nepal Police's Nita Lamsal advanced to the women's singles semifinal.

Elgar to end int'l career

Johannesburg (AFP): Former South Africa Test captain Dean Elgar announced Friday that he will retire from international cricket after a Test series against India starting next week.

The 36-year-old, who has hit more than 5,000 Test runs including 13 centuries, will play his last Test at the Newlands ground in Cape Town starting January 3. "As they say, 'all good things come to an end', and the Indian home series will be my last, as I have made the decision to retire from our beautiful game," Elgar declared.

Elgar made his debut against Australia 12 years ago, failing to score in each innings. Since then he has become known as a stubborn batter, his 5,146 runs making him South Africa's eighth highest scorer. He hit a career best 199 against Bangladesh in 2017.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:51 am, Sunset at 5:14 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly areas and mainly fair in rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at one or two places of hilly regions of Karnali Province. Possibility of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	18.2	6.3	0.0
Dipayal	23.0	5.5	0.0
Dhangadi	25.9	8.5	0.0
Birendranagar	23.2	5.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.5	10.0	0.0
Jumla	19.9	-3.3	0.0
Ghorahi	23.5	8.0	0.0
Pokhara	21.5	7.6	0.0
Bhairahawa	25.2	9.9	0.0
Simara	25.7	9.4	0.0
Kathmandu	18.6	5.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.6	8.8	0.0
Taplejung	17.7	6.0	0.0
Dhankuta	22.2	8.7	0.0
Biratnagar	27.4	10.8	0.0
Jomsom	18.1	-1.0	0.0*
Dharan	26.6	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.5	6.2	0.0*
Janakpur	28.5	9.8	0.0*
Jiri	17.2	0.4	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES
December 23, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.73	Rs. 133.33
Euro	1	Rs. 146.35	Rs. 147.01
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.08	Rs. 169.85
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.48	Rs. 156.18
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.35	Rs. 90.76
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.00	Rs. 100.45
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.29	Rs. 100.74
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.34	Rs. 9.39
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.63	Rs. 18.71
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.41	Rs. 36.58
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.84	Rs. 3.86
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.66	Rs. 28.78
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.23	Rs. 10.27
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.23	Rs. 13.28
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.63	Rs. 19.72
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.99	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.26	Rs. 434.21
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.05	Rs. 353.64

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

ELECTION IS LIFE OF DEMOCRACY: PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
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Chief Election Commissioner Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya presented the 17th annual report to President Paudel in accordance with the Article 294 of the Constitution at a ceremony held at the Office of the President.

On the occasion, President Paudel thanked the EC for successfully concluding the elections of the House of Representatives (HoR) and Provincial Assemblies, of the President and Vice President and the by-elections of the HoR last year.

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During the election, 61.5 per cent voters cast votes.

According to the report, EC had received a budget of Rs. 8.50 billion for the HoR and the Provincial Assembly elections. Of that, Rs. 6.55 was spent and remaining Rs. 1.94 billion was returned to the Finance Ministry.

Election Commissioners and Secretary of the EC were present on the occasion.

PM inaugurates nation's second largest power substation

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Inaruwa, Dec. 22

A 400 kV capacity Inaruwa substation constructed in Bhokraha Narsingh Rural Municipality-4 of Sunsari district has been inaugurated.

Built to strengthen the electricity transmission and distribution system, it is the second-largest substation in Nepal after the Dhalkebar substation.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' inaugurated the substation based on the gas insulated system (GIS) at Bhokraha in Sunsari on Friday.

Two substations of 400 and 220 kV have been constructed in Inaruwa.

The 400 kV substation has been constructed in Inaruwa under the National Electricity Development Decade Programme in the joint investment of the government and the Nepal Electricity Authority.

Three 400 kV substations were proposed under the programme, and the first was built in Dhalkebar, Dhanusha, while the one built in Inaruwa is the second. Construction of the third 400 kV has reached the final stage in Hetauda.

Likewise, the 220/132/33 kV substation was built under the Nepal-India Electricity Transmission and Trade Project with the investment of the government and the Authority and the World Bank's subsidised loan.

The construction cost of the 400 kV and 200 kV substations is about Rs. 3.83 billion.

After inaugurating the substation, Prime Minister Prachanda said that it was constructed and inaugurated to address the domestic electricity demand and export it to India and Bangladesh.

He said that the substation would help the electricity trade with India and Bangladesh and improve the economy of Nepal.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the completion of such large-scale infrastructures has sent a message of hope at a time when despair was being spread among people that nothing was done in the country.

He said that the substation has solved the problem of local power tripping.

"The Inaruwa substation has been established as a hub for east-west electricity supply and electricity trade with the neighbouring country India," he said. "It will light not only the houses and settlements but will also contribute to the country's prosperity and development."

Recalling that the government led by him in the past had freed the people from the terrible era of long-hour load-shedding and taken forward the journey of bright Nepal, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "At that time there was the problem of load-shedding in the urban areas and more than half of the country's villages were still in the dark, now about 98 per cent of the population has access to electricity. The golden day to announce complete electrification of the country within one to two years is coming soon."

He said that the government was making important decisions on the use of forest areas for the construction of transmission lines.

"Within a few days, we are making some historic and important decisions to distribute land to the landless squatters. My first year in office is going to be completed soon. Now onward, we will work to push development activities further forward and maintain good governance," he said.

"The initial agreement inked on long-term electricity trade with India during my visit to the southern neighbour has ensured the market to develop the immense potential of hydropower in Nepal. To implement the initial agreement, we are soon signing the final agreement in the presence of the high level Indian officials in Nepal, this will be another important and historic opening in Nepal's hydropower development," he said.

On the occasion, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet said that energy had contributed significantly to the development of the country.

He said that the substation proved to be an important milestone not only in the development of electricity but also in exploiting water resources.

He said that development has given hope rather than despair and that the current government has done many things that have not been done since 1968 B.S.

Minister Basnet said that 500 megawatts of electricity was produced within one year and another 500 megawatts of electricity would be added to the national grid in the next year.

Mentioning that there is a reliable base to produce about 30,000 megawatts of electricity within the next 10 years, Minister Basnet said that additional legal arrangements will be made to address the right-of-way problem and the demands of the locals for the construction of the transmission lines.

Managing director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the Inaruwa substation is the backbone for the transmission of electricity produced by hydropower projects in various districts of Koshi Province for local consumption and export to India.

This substation will help improve the local supply of power, he said. "This will improve the voltage in the area and the electricity supply will be reliable and qualitative."

"The Inaruwa-Purnia 400 kV international line for electricity trade with India and Inaruwa-Anarmani 400 kV transmission line for trade between Nepal, India and Bangladesh has been proposed from this substation," he said.

The 400/220 kV Inaruwa substation has three power transformers, each having a capacity 315 MVA.

Similarly, there are two power transformers of 220/132 kV 160 MVA capacity and 220/33 kV, 63 MVA capacity.

After the construction of the Inaruwa-Dhalkebar 400 kV transmission line, around 4,000 megawatts of electricity can be supplied from the Inaruwa substation. The wire pulling of the Inaruwa-Dhalkebar transmission line is now underway.



Photo: PM's Secretariat

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' observing Inaruwa sub-station after its inauguration in Jhokraha of Sunsari on Friday.

Road to Prosperity

- Two substations of 400 and 220 kV have been constructed in Inaruwa.
- The construction cost of the 400 kV and 200 kV substations is about Rs. 3.83 billion.
- The substation will help the electricity trade with India and Bangladesh.

'ECONOMY IS NOT IN DIRE SITUATION'

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 22

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the country's economy is not in a dire situation like it was a year ago. While speaking at the inaugural programme of a trade expo organised by the Chamber of Industries Morang (CIM) on Friday in Biratnagar, the Prime Minister said that the indicators of the economy were positive.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that with the help of the private sector, the inflation which was at 7.11 per cent has come down to 5.38 per cent now. Stating that a comfortable situation has been created in terms of balance of payments, he clarified that there were signs of improvement in bank interest rates while the situation is being improved in micro-finance and cooperatives sectors as well. Stating that in the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 Nepal is witnessing Rs. 120 billion remittance inflow every month, PM Prachanda said that the reserve of the current FY is at Rs. 16.96 billion. "Some14 months ago, the loan interest rate had reached above 18 per cent, now it is below 12 per cent," he said.

Stating that good governance and social justice had been established one year after he took the reign of the government, he asked to turn the criticism into a positive one. PM Prachanda expressed concerns over the negative nature of civil and business activities and comments even though the economy is getting back on track, and emphasised that intellectuals and industrialists should come forward to change this into a positive one.

Stating that Biratnagar has political significance, PM Prachanda maintained that any argument of non-cooperation in the development of this city cannot be accepted. He said that the policy problems in the operation of the inaugurated cargo rail will be resolved immediately, Girija Prasad Koirala Cricket Stadium will be promoted as a project of national pride and the government will be positive in ensuring the budget for the ring road in the coming Fiscal Year 2024/25.

Similarly, PM Prachanda assured that a decision will be taken soon on the matter of maintaining the entry permit through the checkpoint and maintaining the affiliation of Koshi to Mount Everest to facilitate the arrival of tourists in the provincial capital of Koshi.

Speaking on the occasion, Nepali Congress leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala, complained that although Biratnagar is standing on its own feet, the government was not paying attention to development. He demanded that the federal government address the issues at Biratnagar Ring road, Bathanaha-Viratnagar cargo rail, Biratnagar airport upgradation and industrial exhibition.

Meanwhile, industrialists and businesspersons of Biratnagar facilitated Prime Minister Prachanda.

'Digital technology must for economic transformation'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that digital transformation and building a digital ecosystem are necessary for the economic transformation of the country.

Addressing the eighth edition of the ICT Awards organised by Living with ICT on Friday, Minister Sharma said that the government was formulating necessary policy, legal and structural arrangements for this transformation.

She said, "The government considers information and communication technology (ICT) as a basic need and a national priority."

Minister Sharma said that information technology was an important basis for the development of the digital economy, and to compete with the world.

Minister Sharma further stressed that the government has passed the National Cyber Security Policy-2080 B.S (2023), to create cyber laws and establish a National Cyber Security Centre.

Minister Sharma also informed that the government was organising new programmes like ICT Exhibition and Digital Champion to encourage start-ups in the information technology sector this year.

Minister Sharma stressed that digital skill programmes would be implemented in all seven provinces to retain youths in the country by creating job opportunities.

Bardiya boy's app sold at Rs. 7 million

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Dec. 22

A mobile application developed by 22-year-old Karna Bahadur Budha Chhetri has sold for over Rs. 7 million.

Chhetri, who lives in Bansgadhi Municipality-5, Bardiya, and has a diploma in computer engineering from the Nepalgunj Technical College, made an app called 'Pickup Lines.' And, according to his college, the Israeli company Rounds AI Ltd. purchased it for US$ 53,000.

Talking to The Rising Nepal, Chhetri said that his app contained a collection of pickup lines that would help people have sweet, fun and memorable conversations with their friends and family members.

He said that the app would run on all versions of Android above Android 5.1 and informed that he had uploaded the app to the Google Play Store in November of last year. Since then, it has been downloaded over 500,000 times, he said.



"The pickup lines in the app have been divided into cheesy, romantic, cute, funny and other categories. The users can easily copy the lines and paste them on social media chats, emails or text messages," Chhetri said. "The app was attracting a lot of users from Africa and Europe and had started to make good money."

Chhetri also informed that Rounds AI had made a previous offer to buy his app. But the money was too low. They later upped their offer and convinced him to sell.

Kishor Kumar Pandey, managing director of Nepalgunj Technical College, said that the entire college was extremely proud of Chhetri's achievement and wished him further success in the future.

Meanwhile, the college's Principal Chhining Lal Thapa Magar hoped that Chhetri would inspire other students as well.

To date, Chhetri has developed over a dozen apps and has uploaded them to Play Store under the name 'Kaki Developers.' Some of those apps have over 100,000 downloads.

Some of Chhetri's most popular apps include 'Class 9 Nepali Guide Book,' 'Class 8 Nepali Guide Book,' 'Nepali Byakaran' and 'Nepali Samaya Gyan Offline.'

NC'S BAGMATI PROVINCE CONFERENCE TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

Nepali Congress Bagmati Province Committee decided to hold the party's first Bagmati conference on Saturday.

Committee chair Indra Bahadur Baniya organising a press meet in the Capital on Friday informed that preparations for the conference were completed.

NC president Sher Bahadur Deuba will inaugurate the conference which will be attended by the province representatives of 13 districts.

Baniya said that the agenda of the conference were federalism, secularism and a proportional electoral system.

» SEE PAGE 6

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He said that the substation would help the electricity trade with India and Bangladesh and improve the economy of Nepal.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the completion of such large-scale infrastructures has sent a message of hope at a time when despair was being spread among people that nothing was done in the country.

He said that the substation has solved the problem of local power tripping.

"The Inaruwa substation has been established as a hub for east-west electricity supply and electricity trade with the neighbouring country India," he said. "It will light not only the houses and settlements but will also contribute to the country's prosperity and development."

Recalling that the government led by him in the past had freed the people from the terrible era of long-hour load-shedding and taken forward the journey of bright Nepal, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "At that time there was the problem of load-shedding in the urban areas and more than half of the country's villages were still in the dark, now about 98 per cent of the population has access to electricity. The golden day to announce complete electrification of the country within one to two years is coming soon."

He said that the government was making important decisions on the use of forest areas for the construction of transmission lines.

"Within a few days, we are making some historic and important decisions to distribute land to the landless squatters. My first year in office is going to be completed soon. Now onward, we will work to push development activities further forward and maintain good governance," he said.

"The initial agreement inked on long-term electricity trade with India during my visit to the southern neighbour has ensured the market to develop the immense potential of hydropower in Nepal. To implement the initial agreement, we are soon signing the final agreement in the presence of the high level Indian officials in Nepal, this will be another important and historic opening in Nepal's hydropower development," he said.

On the occasion, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet said that energy had contributed significantly to the development of the country.

He said that the substation proved to be an important milestone not only in the development of electricity but also in exploiting water resources.

He said that development has given hope rather than despair and that the current government has done many things that have not been done since 1968 B.S.

Minister Basnet said that 500 megawatts of electricity was produced within one year and another 500 megawatts of electricity would be added to the national grid in the next year.

Mentioning that there is a reliable base to produce about 30,000 megawatts of electricity within the next 10 years, Minister Basnet said that additional legal arrangements will be made to address the right-of-way problem and the demands of the locals for the construction of the transmission lines.

Managing director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the Inaruwa substation is the backbone for the transmission of electricity produced by hydropower projects in various districts of Koshi Province for local consumption and export to India.

This substation will help improve the local supply of power, he said. "This will improve the voltage in the area and the electricity supply will be reliable and qualitative."

"The Inaruwa-Purnia 400 kV international line for electricity trade with India and Inaruwa-Anarmani 400 kV transmission line for trade between Nepal, India and Bangladesh has been proposed from this substation," he said.

The 400/220 kV Inaruwa substation has three power transformers, each having a capacity 315 MVA.

Similarly, there are two power transformers of 220/132 kV 160 MVA capacity and 220/33 kV, 63 MVA capacity.

After the construction of the Inaruwa-Dhalkebar 400 kV transmission line, around 4,000 megawatts of electricity can be supplied from the Inaruwa substation. The wire pulling of the Inaruwa-Dhalkebar transmission line is now underway.



Photo: PM's Secretariat

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' observing Inaruwa sub-station after its inauguration in Jhokraha of Sunsari on Friday.

Road to Prosperity

- Two substations of 400 and 220 kV have been constructed in Inaruwa.
- The construction cost of the 400 kV and 200 kV substations is about Rs. 3.83 billion.
- The substation will help the electricity trade with India and Bangladesh.

'ECONOMY IS NOT IN DIRE SITUATION'

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 22

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the country's economy is not in a dire situation like it was a year ago. While speaking at the inaugural programme of a trade expo organised by the Chamber of Industries Morang (CIM) on Friday in Biratnagar, the Prime Minister said that the indicators of the economy were positive.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that with the help of the private sector, the inflation which was at 7.11 per cent has come down to 5.38 per cent now. Stating that a comfortable situation has been created in terms of balance of payments, he clarified that there were signs of improvement in bank interest rates while the situation is being improved in micro-finance and cooperatives sectors as well. Stating that in the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 Nepal is witnessing Rs. 120 billion remittance inflow every month, PM Prachanda said that the reserve of the current FY is at Rs. 16.96 billion. "Some14 months ago, the loan interest rate had reached above 18 per cent, now it is below 12 per cent," he said.

Stating that good governance and social justice had been established one year after he took the reign of the government, he asked to turn the criticism into a positive one. PM Prachanda expressed concerns over the negative nature of civil and business activities and comments even though the economy is getting back on track, and emphasised that intellectuals and industrialists should come forward to change this into a positive one.

Stating that Biratnagar has political significance, PM Prachanda maintained that any argument of non-cooperation in the development of this city cannot be accepted. He said that the policy problems in the operation of the inaugurated cargo rail will be resolved immediately, Girija Prasad Koirala Cricket Stadium will be promoted as a project of national pride and the government will be positive in ensuring the budget for the ring road in the coming Fiscal Year 2024/25.

Similarly, PM Prachanda assured that a decision will be taken soon on the matter of maintaining the entry permit through the checkpoint and maintaining the affiliation of Koshi to Mount Everest to facilitate the arrival of tourists in the provincial capital of Koshi.

Speaking on the occasion, Nepali Congress leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala, complained that although Biratnagar is standing on its own feet, the government was not paying attention to development. He demanded that the federal government address the issues at Biratnagar Ring road, Bathanaha-Viratnagar cargo rail, Biratnagar airport upgradation and industrial exhibition.

Meanwhile, industrialists and businesspersons of Biratnagar facilitated Prime Minister Prachanda.

'Digital technology must for economic transformation'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that digital transformation and building a digital ecosystem are necessary for the economic transformation of the country.

Addressing the eighth edition of the ICT Awards organised by Living with ICT on Friday, Minister Sharma said that the government was formulating necessary policy, legal and structural arrangements for this transformation.

She said, "The government considers information and communication technology (ICT) as a basic need and a national priority."

Minister Sharma said that information technology was an important basis for the development of the digital economy, and to compete with the world.

Minister Sharma further stressed that the government has passed the National Cyber Security Policy-2080 B.S (2023), to create cyber laws and establish a National Cyber Security Centre.

Minister Sharma also informed that the government was organising new programmes like ICT Exhibition and Digital Champion to encourage start-ups in the information technology sector this year.

Minister Sharma stressed that digital skill programmes would be implemented in all seven provinces to retain youths in the country by creating job opportunities.

Bardiya boy's app sold at Rs. 7 million

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Dec. 22

A mobile application developed by 22-year-old Karna Bahadur Budha Chhetri has sold for over Rs. 7 million.

Chhetri, who lives in Bansgadhi Municipality-5, Bardiya, and has a diploma in computer engineering from the Nepalgunj Technical College, made an app called 'Pickup Lines.' And, according to his college, the Israeli company Rounds AI Ltd. purchased it for US$ 53,000.

Talking to The Rising Nepal, Chhetri said that his app contained a collection of pickup lines that would help people have sweet, fun and memorable conversations with their friends and family members.

He said that the app would run on all versions of Android above Android 5.1 and informed that he had uploaded the app to the Google Play Store in November of last year. Since then, it has been downloaded over 500,000 times, he said.



"The pickup lines in the app have been divided into cheesy, romantic, cute, funny and other categories. The users can easily copy the lines and paste them on social media chats, emails or text messages," Chhetri said. "The app was attracting a lot of users from Africa and Europe and had started to make good money."

Chhetri also informed that Rounds AI had made a previous offer to buy his app. But the money was too low. They later upped their offer and convinced him to sell.

Kishor Kumar Pandey, managing director of Nepalgunj Technical College, said that the entire college was extremely proud of Chhetri's achievement and wished him further success in the future.

Meanwhile, the college's Principal Chhining Lal Thapa Magar hoped that Chhetri would inspire other students as well.

To date, Chhetri has developed over a dozen apps and has uploaded them to Play Store under the name 'Kaki Developers.' Some of those apps have over 100,000 downloads.

Some of Chhetri's most popular apps include 'Class 9 Nepali Guide Book,' 'Class 8 Nepali Guide Book,' 'Nepali Byakaran' and 'Nepali Samaya Gyan Offline.'

NC'S BAGMATI PROVINCE CONFERENCE TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 22

Nepali Congress Bagmati Province Committee decided to hold the party's first Bagmati conference on Saturday.

Committee chair Indra Bahadur Baniya organising a press meet in the Capital on Friday informed that preparations for the conference were completed.

NC president Sher Bahadur Deuba will inaugurate the conference which will be attended by the province representatives of 13 districts.

Baniya said that the agenda of the conference were federalism, secularism and a proportional electoral system.

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